ENGLISH TRANSLATION PREVIEW

# Understanding Human Nature

## Relationships, Boundaries, and Cooperation

KK

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# Copyright and Reading Notice

English reader preview, November 2026. By KK.

This is an AI-assisted English translation draft of the Chinese reader edition. It has not completed human target-language review. Suggestions about accuracy, naturalness, and cultural clarity are welcome; this preview is not presented as an approved final English edition.

My native language is Chinese. I welcome corrections and suggestions from native English speakers to help make this English edition clearer and more natural while preserving its meaning. — KK

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The book begins with questions prompted by works such as Carnegie's *How to Win Friends and Influence People*—commonly known in Chinese as *Renxing de Ruodian*—and develops an independent discussion informed by psychology, social science, and philosophy. It is not a translation of those works and does not imply endorsement by their authors, institutions, or publishers. The narrative cases are fictional, as stated in the chapters. Au-

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# Preface

I wanted to begin with classics such as Dale Carnegie's *How to Win Friends and Influence People* and broaden the way I understood human relationships. One author's experience in one period can be a starting point for inquiry. I hope to keep exploring books and research from China and other countries on human nature, communication, cooperation, and the choices we make in life, comparing insights developed in different settings.

Bringing these perspectives together requires understanding the question each addresses, the circumstances in which it may apply, and the disagreements between them. Which insights complement one another? Which claims need reconsideration in a different relationship, institution, or cultural setting? These are questions this book keeps returning to.

I also want to use AI to organize material from around the world, compare explanations, identify gaps, and develop independent interpretations of the questions this book asks. Readers should be able to distinguish what previous authors propose, what research actually supports, and what this book goes on to suggest.

In the chapters themselves, I want to explain why people may react in a certain way before discussing what they could do. Why do we hurry to defend ourselves? Why do we so easily treat assumptions as facts? Why can familiar relationships allow expectations to cross boundaries? These questions need explanations of human responses, concrete stories, and scientific grounding.

The book follows a sequence: what tendencies people display, why these responses arise, how they affect judgment, behavior, and relationships, and what we might therefore do. Tendencies need to be understood within particular circumstances. Respect, honesty, autonomy, and sustainable cooperation are explicit values of this book.

The six parts and seventeen chapters move from understanding our own reactions and other people's circumstances to care, conversation, cooperation, and repairing relationships. The final part considers how to apply what we have learned to everyday choices.

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Part I

# Understanding Our Own Reactions

**Chapter 1**

# Why Knowing What to Do Is Not Enough

*The characters, events, and dialogue in this chapter are original fiction.*

After discovering a mistake, why might someone become so intent on putting it right that they take even longer to tell the people working with them?

We can want to do a job well and preserve other people's good opinion of us at the same time. Taking corrective action makes us feel responsible; admitting a mistake brings immediate embarrassment. When these needs collide, we may keep telling ourselves: wait a little longer, solve it first, then say something.

This chapter makes a distinction: understanding a principle answers "What do I agree with?" but not yet "What am I willing to bear in order to act on it?" Changing what we do therefore takes more than another attempt to persuade ourselves. We also need to recognize the cost we are avoiding and promptly disclose the part that affects others.

# 1 A story: she kept trying to fix the problem, so why was her colleague still angry?

On Wednesday afternoon, Xu Yi discovered two errors in the dimensions of the exhibition information cards. Remaking them would take a day. Meng Qiao, who was responsible for setting up the exhibition, had already scheduled installation for Thursday.

She opened the chat window and typed, “There’s a problem with the dimensions.” Then she deleted it. In the previous exchange, Meng Qiao had asked her yesterday whether everything had been checked. She had replied, “All fine.”

She knew she should tell him. But if she changed her answer now, would he think he could no longer trust her with the work?

Contacting the supplier was much easier. She urged them to rush the replacements, asked whether they could arrive by the next morning, and kept her phone beside her while she waited for a reply. If the cards arrived in time, installation could go ahead unchanged, and she would not have to explain herself over those two errors.

She continued to tell Meng Qiao, “Prepare according to the original plan.”

The replacement cards did not arrive in time the next day. Meng Qiao brought the installation crew to the site and only then learned that the original arrangements could not go ahead. Xu Yi hurried to explain: “I was already chasing them yesterday. Remaking them was supposed to take only a day. I wanted to solve the problem first.”

Meng Qiao asked, “You knew yesterday. Why am I only finding out today?”

Xu Yi did not feel she had ignored the mistake. She had spent time trying to correct it and had wanted the exhibition to go smoothly all along. But Meng Qiao was concerned about something else: he could have adjusted the staffing and the order of work in advance. Now everyone was already there.

After the exhibition, Xu Yi wrote down, “Don’t make mistakes again.” Meng Qiao suggested clarifying their handover arrangements first: whenever dimensions, quantities, or delivery dates might affect the next stage, tell the relevant person that same day, identifying anything that remained uncertain.

# 2 Understanding what gets in the way of action

## Agreeing with a principle and accepting its cost

Xu Yi wanted to correct the mistake and continue to be seen as a reliable colleague. The issue was not whether her intentions were good. To protect that second goal for the moment, she left Meng Qiao exposed to a risk he knew nothing about.

If she told him immediately, the embarrassment was certain and immediate. If she said nothing for now, a delay was still only a possibility. To her, waiting seemed to buy more time to fix things. To Meng Qiao, that same period of waiting reduced his room to rearrange the work.

This is a trade-off the book asks us to notice: while protecting one of our own needs, we may transfer another part of the cost of our actions to someone else. Asking only “Did I try hard?” can obscure “Who bore the consequences of my decision?” Once we see this trade-off, honesty is not merely a personal virtue. It also concerns whether the people working with us can make their own choices.

Knowing, wanting to act, and actually acting also need to be distinguished. Webb and Sheeran’s synthesis of experimental research distinguishes changes in behavioral intentions from changes in behavior. [1] In everyday life, saying “I want to do a good job too” does not yet explain how action will happen.

The next question needs to be specific: do you not know how to say it, are you unable to act, or are you unwilling to bear the cost of speaking up?

If Xu Yi did not know the delivery date, she needed to obtain information and report that it was still unconfirmed. If she did not know how to notify Meng Qiao, she needed to organize what was known and unknown clearly. If she already knew how to tell him but was waiting until it would no longer be embarrassing, she needed to change the rule governing her wait. If there had been no way to contact anyone that day, the first problem to solve would have been the communication channel, not an assumed decision to conceal the mistake.

Different obstacles call for different responses. “Poor follow-through” bundles them into one label without showing what needs to change next.

## Telling the truth when the outcome is uncertain

Xu Yi's strongest defense was: "Yesterday I didn't know it would definitely be late. Why worry everyone for nothing?"

Because Meng Qiao did not need an accurate prediction of tomorrow. He needed the information on which tomorrow's arrangements depended. The dimensions were already wrong: that was a fact. Whether the replacements would be ready in time was unknown. What was unknown did not cancel what was known.

On Wednesday, she could have said: "Two dimensions need correcting, so the cards have to be remade. The supplier hasn't confirmed whether they can deliver by tomorrow morning. I'm following up. Please don't lock in the entire installation schedule yet. I'll update you at four this afternoon."

That message would have shown Meng Qiao what he needed to decide: keep waiting, install other parts first, or ask another supplier. It would also have allowed Xu Yi to keep working on the problem while involving her colleague in the arrangements. She did not need to guarantee success before she was entitled to report progress.

The principle of cooperation adopted here is this: when information you already have will materially affect someone else's arrangements, give the relevant people a timely opportunity to take it into account. This means information needed for the task. Private and confidential material must still be handled according to responsibilities and agreements. Saying only "Everything might be ruined," or passing on all your anxiety, is no substitute for an accurate update.

Once the facts are clear, the consequences already caused still need to be addressed. Xu Yi can explain that she feared appearing unreliable. Meng Qiao can understand that concern and still ask her to deal with the delay. Understanding motives and holding someone responsible answer different questions.

If a team publicly humiliates people whenever they report an error, speaking up carries a real additional cost. Improvement then requires more than asking individuals to be braver. The reporting channels, traceable records, and available support also need examining. What someone could have done at the time must still be judged against the actual conditions.

## Turning resolve into a choice you can make next time

“Don’t make mistakes again” expressed Xu Yi’s wish but did not specify what to do when she discovered the next error. The handover agreement turned that wish into an action: report information that affects the next stage on the same day, making the uncertainties clear as well.

The agreement also separated two things: reporting a mistake does not require first proving how reliable you are. Promptly explaining a problem is itself a responsibility you can take in cooperative work. Chapter 16 returns to how reminders, rehearsal, and procedures can help an action happen.

If the cards had happened to arrive in time and Meng Qiao had not become angry, withholding the information on Wednesday would not thereby have become appropriate. Evaluating the

choice requires looking at the information available and the responsibility to notify others, not just the luck of the final outcome.

## Returning to the opening question

When you understand a principle but do not act on it, one possibility worth examining is that you agree with it yet give priority to protecting another need when the moment comes. Useful change begins with recognizing that trade-off, then specifying how you will bear the immediate cost next time.

In a shared task, the answer can be concrete: when you discover a problem that affects others' arrangements, explain what is known, what remains unknown, and when you will update them, then continue working on the solution. You do not have to wait until a problem is solved before letting someone know it exists.

**Source note** [1] Webb and Sheeran (2006), original article abstract, R08. The material consulted was limited to the abstract and bibliographic information; the full text was not checked. Behavioral intention in this research is not the same as "understanding a principle," and the research does not establish the psychological causes of a fictional character's actions. The account of competing goals and embarrassment, the notification standard, and the judgments about responsibility are this book's synthesis and value choices. The fictional story illustrates these distinctions; it is not evidence of universal laws of human nature or of teaching effectiveness. See References and Scope of Consultation.

**Chapter 2**

# How Self-Esteem Can Motivate Us and Make Us Defensive

*The characters, creative work, events, and dialogue in this chapter are original fiction.*

Someone says, “This wasn’t done well,” but what you hear is, “You’re no good.” Once the discussion reaches that point, even specific feedback can turn into a battle to defend the self.

We may treat certain abilities, identities, or other people’s approval as evidence of our worth. They can motivate us to invest effort. They can also give a single failure too much meaning: doing something badly begins to feel like no longer deserving respect.

This chapter’s argument is that protecting self-esteem does not require defending every outcome. Acknowledging a particular weakness, retaining a reasonable disagreement, and rejecting genuine belittlement need to be handled separately. When we mix them together, we can become so intent on proving our worth that we abandon information we could have used.

# 1 First, the distinction: why can a comment feel so painful?

## Having a sense of worth does not mean always being right

Valuing your abilities can make you take a task seriously. Caring about the quality of your work can give you standards for what you deliver. That concern can be a source of strength. The deeper question is whether you require every performance to prove, “I am a person who deserves recognition.”

Crocker and Knight propose that the conditions on which people base their self-worth can be sources of motivation as well as psychological vulnerability. [1] From this perspective, when receiving feedback, it is worth identifying what the other person evaluated and what you understood that evaluation to mean.

A performance that falls short may concern a method, an outcome, or the standard used to evaluate it. Getting from there to “I can’t do anything well” or “I have no value” requires several further inferences. If those steps are skipped, the other person is discussing one thing while you are defending your whole self. The more both of you say, the further apart the conversation may move.

Defensiveness then carries a cost. When you rush to explain why someone is unqualified to judge, you ask less about what their feedback actually concerns. When you are busy proving how many things you did right in the past, you look less closely at what went wrong this time. Self-esteem is protected for the moment, but the original problem remains untouched.

What deserves protection is basic dignity. This book takes the position that people do not need to perform perfectly every time to earn respect. Examining a particular performance does not have to become a rejection of the whole person.

## Accepting one point does not mean surrendering your judgment

How can you receive feedback without falling into wholesale self-rejection?

Bring the evaluation back to the behavior or result it concerns and ask about the evidence. If one point is supported by facts, acknowledge that point. If another remains disputed, explain the specific reasons. Acceptance and disagreement can each have their own scope. You need not deny an established problem in order to maintain a different objection.

The same applies to the person giving feedback. If you are responsible for a decision, you can explain the standard. If you do not know part of the background, you can acknowledge that you need more information. Responsibility for a role does not require pretending to know everything.

## If the feedback itself is problematic, address that problem

When feedback shifts from specific behavior to belittling someone's background, identity, or whole person, the recipient's emotional self-management is not enough to resolve it. The problem with the expression itself needs to be identified, and the speaker asked to provide specific grounds.

If humiliation continues, you can end the discussion and consider appealing the decision or withdrawing. If rules change without warning or are applied inconsistently to different people, check the notices, standards, and decision-making process. When the other person holds decision-making power and your choices are constrained, these actions can have real costs. You need to decide according to your circumstances.

Acknowledging a weakness does not mean endorsing every aspect of the evaluation process. Equally, feeling hurt by feedback does not, on its own, establish that the speaker is humiliating you. Returning to the actual words, facts, and rules helps distinguish what needs improvement from what needs to be challenged.

## 2 A story: four photographs were selected, so why did they still argue about qualifications?

Xu Zheng submitted six photographs to a neighborhood exhibition. The curator, Wen Qi, selected four and returned two: the edges of the figure in one were too dark, and the other did not clearly connect with the exhibition's theme.

He read the two comments and remembered the poster for the previous event. It had called him "the person who understands this neighborhood best." Those words had pleased him. Now that two photographs had been returned, he felt that his understanding of the place was being rejected as well.

He replied, "You haven't lived here. You don't know what real life here is like."

Wen Qi began talking about her curatorial experience. She felt Xu Zheng was questioning her qualifications; he felt she was using those qualifications to overrule a resident's understanding of life there. Both began defending themselves. No one continued discussing what needed changing in the photographs.

Later, Xu Zheng suggested looking at the projected images again. He would respond to the specific comments the following day.

When the projection came on, he walked closer, then stepped back to the viewing position. The details around the figure's edges really were unclear. He knew what the person in the photograph was doing, but viewers did not have his memories.

"The dark areas in this one need adjusting," he said.

Acknowledging that still felt uncomfortable. He wanted to add quickly, "They aren't all like this." But the discussion stayed with that photograph rather than turning into a verdict on his entire ability.

He still disagreed about the other image. He wanted to show a shoe-repair shop gradually disappearing. Wen Qi said viewers could see the shop but not the change.

Xu Zheng wanted to add context in the exhibition label. Wen Qi was willing to read it but still wanted before-and-after material. He did not agree immediately; he felt that requirement might sacrifice the photograph's subtlety. Whether the theme was clear and how to provide background remained open questions.

All six photographs were not selected as a result. Xu Zheng opened the overly dark one first, ready to adjust it. Beside the other, Wen Qi's comment about the theme remained.

## Preserve dignity and open up the specific problem

Looking back at Xu Zheng's change, two judgments could now be separated: the details in the dark areas really were unclear in projection, while how to present the theme remained disputed. Acknowledging the first did not require surrendering the second.

He could respond: "The details in the dark areas really aren't clear when projected. I'll adjust those. I still want to discuss the theme, because the changes to that shop are precisely my focus." Accepting the point about the dark areas and maintaining the disagreement over the theme would each have a basis, allowing the discussion to stay with the work.

Now change one condition. If Wen Qi had said, "People from this neighborhood can only take pictures like these," she would have shifted from discussing particular work to disparaging a group. Xu Zheng would need to identify that problem and ask her to return to the photographs and the criteria. A photograph's being too dark would not excuse a belittling comment, nor would it establish that the selection process was fair.

Protecting self-esteem, then, does not mean insisting that every performance must be right. Identify the object of the feedback first. Then acknowledge a shortcoming, explain a disagreement, or challenge belittlement as appropriate. You need not give up the chance to address a specific problem in order to prove your worth as a person.

**Source note** [1] Crocker and Katherine M. Knight (2005), public abstract of *Contingencies of Self-Worth*, R09. Only the public abstract was consulted. The relationship between motivation and vulnerability is presented here as the authors' theoretical argument, not as a personality diagnosis. The treatment of specific feedback, dignity, and procedural fairness is this book's synthesis and value choice. The fictional photography story shows how objects of judgment can be distinguished; it does not establish that the method will necessarily lead to acceptance or selection. See References and Scope of Consultation.

**Chapter 3**

# How We Mistake Assumptions for Facts

*The characters, factory, task records, and dialogue in this chapter are original fiction, not drawn from readers' experiences.*

Work not being finished on time does not mean the person doing it was slacking off. You have seen the outcome. Why it happened still needs to be established.

We can easily treat both an observed behavior and our guess about its cause as facts. Once we decide, "This person has a bad attitude," an explanation sounds like an excuse, while silence sounds like an admission. Everything appears to confirm that something is wrong with the person, although the crucial cause has never been established.

Find out how the delay occurred before deciding what responsibility to assign. Do not rush to excuse someone, but do not rush to treat everything they say as an excuse either.

## 1 A story: why was the packaging machine not repaired on time?

At eight in the morning, workshop supervisor Lu Yan assigned a broken packaging machine to maintenance technician Cheng Yue. Having inspected the fault, Cheng Yue estimated that it

would take four hours to repair. They agreed that it would be ready at noon. A customer's order was due to be loaded that afternoon, so Lu Yan scheduled the packing work for after lunch.

At noon, the machine was still stopped. Cheng Yue sat at a workbench looking at the repair sheet. It said only "Started at eight," with no further progress recorded.

Lu Yan flared up. "Everyone down the line is waiting. Why are you still sitting here? You don't seem to care at all."

Cheng Yue said, "I've just come back from the loading area. The conveyor belt stopped."

That only annoyed Lu Yan further. "This machine isn't fixed, and now you're talking about something else." The more Cheng Yue explained, the more Lu Yan thought he was shifting responsibility. Seeing him pause to look through a form also seemed like evidence that he was dragging his feet.

Then the warehouse asked whether the afternoon's loading arrangements needed changing. Lu Yan needed an accurate time; simply saying "Hurry up" would not help. He asked Cheng Yue to describe the morning's work in chronological order and bring both repair sheets.

The other sheet recorded that at ten, the loading team's shift leader had called Cheng Yue away for an urgent conveyor repair. It had finished at noon, with the shift leader's signature at the bottom. Lu Yan checked with the person on duty and confirmed those times.

Of the four hours, Cheng Yue had spent two repairing another machine. He had not been lingering beside the packaging machine all morning. “You’ve been repairing it since eight; why isn’t it ready?” left out what had happened in between.

But Cheng Yue also acknowledged that, because the other team had been pressing him, he had gone straight over without asking the two supervisors to confirm the priority or telling Lu Yan that the packaging machine would be late. He had thought he could update the paperwork afterward. Meanwhile, Lu Yan had kept staffing arrangements based on the original time.

Cheng Yue gave a new progress estimate: the packaging machine needed about two more hours. The planned packing work had to be rescheduled, and loading needed rearranging too. Lu Yan went to coordinate with the warehouse and agreed with the loading team’s shift leader how urgent maintenance requests should be communicated. Cheng Yue entered the actual working times for both jobs in the records. The machine did not return to operation until the afternoon.

Lu Yan no longer attributed the whole delay to Cheng Yue’s “not caring.” Cheng Yue’s failure to communicate the task change promptly was not erased either.

# 2 When work is late, do not rush to decide why

## Say what happened before saying what you think caused it

Lu Yan had reason to be anxious: the packaging machine was not running on time, and its repair sheet had not been updated. Both issues needed addressing.

Lu Yan could see that the machine was not repaired. He had not established whether Cheng Yue was deliberately delaying it. He thought Cheng Yue had been working on that machine since eight; in fact, Cheng Yue had spent two hours repairing the conveyor belt.

Once we decide that someone has a bad attitude, it becomes easy to interpret everything we subsequently hear in that light. Cheng Yue's explanation that he had been in the loading area sounded like shifting responsibility. Looking through the repair sheets looked like dawdling. Whatever he did, it became difficult to prompt Lu Yan to reconsider.

A better question at that point was: had he been working on this machine the whole time, or had something else occupied him that Lu Yan did not know about? [1] Then obtain the other repair sheet, check with the person on duty, and see whether other work had taken up the time.

## Ask about specific events

“Do you just not care?” is difficult to verify. Cheng Yue could only say that he did care, and Lu Yan could still see that answer as self-justification.

“What time were you called to the loading area, and when did you finish? Why isn’t that period recorded on the packaging machine’s sheet?” is much more specific. They can examine the records together, check with the person on duty, and decide how to schedule the afternoon’s work.

The same applies when pointing out a problem. “The machine still can’t be used at noon, there’s no progress on the sheet, and the later staffing arrangements have been disrupted” puts the matters needing attention in front of both people. [2] Lu Yan still expects machines to be repaired on time. But Cheng Yue hears more than a criticism of his attitude: he knows what he needs to explain.

If you are the person being questioned, do not simply repeat, “I wasn’t slacking off.” Explain the work you actually did, the time it took, and what you failed to communicate promptly. That gives the other person an opportunity to reassess what happened.

## Establishing the cause does not mean no one is responsible

Cheng Yue had indeed been doing another urgent repair; he could not be said to have wasted the whole morning. He had nevertheless failed to confirm which task took priority or update the records promptly, and he still needed to take responsibility for that.

Lu Yan needed to change more than his tone. Two supervisors needed the same technician but had not aligned the timing and priorities. The same conflict could arise again. Asking Cheng Yue to “show more initiative” would not put him in two places at once.

Responsibility becomes more precise when the sequence of events is clear: Cheng Yue needs to complete the records; temporarily reallocating him needs to include notice of the job affected; supervisors need to reset priorities. You can criticize a specific omission without first describing the whole person as irresponsible.

## What to do in a situation like this

Start by stating which work remains unfinished, then check the specific arrangements with the other person. Once the facts are clear, change the schedule where needed and complete the records where needed. If the person did omit a step, identify that step and ask them to put it right.

Do not let “He has a bad attitude” replace the checking that should have happened. What you need to know is how the delay actually occurred and which step must be handled differently next time.

**Source notes** [1] Lord, Lepper, and Preston (1984), original article abstract, R10. Consultation was limited to the abstract’s account of two specific social-judgment experiments. Research on considering another possibility does not directly establish the effectiveness of this chapter’s maintenance scenario or questions. [2] BayNVC practical guide, P02. The chapter draws on its approach to describing observed behavior and distinguishing interpretation; a methods guide

is not an experiment establishing causal effects. The recommendations about checking tasks, scheduling, and responsibility are this book's synthesis and value choices. The work orders, durations, and consequences are fictional, not survey data. See References and Scope of Consultation.

Part II

# Understanding Other People's Circumstances

**Chapter 4**

# Why the Same Behavior Can Have Different Causes

*The characters, shops, market, and dialogue in this chapter are original fiction, not drawn from readers' experiences.*

When someone says, "I can't," they may be unwilling. They may also lack time, lack tools, or have no authority to agree. If you treat all of these as "being uncooperative," you may keep urging them to change their attitude without touching the actual problem.

We can see someone refuse, arrive late, or leave a task unfinished. We may not see what resources they have, what they were doing at the time, or whom they are responsible for. Sometimes we can even repeat the reasons they have given and still continue thinking, "That's just the sort of person they are." Missing the background and failing to consider background we already know are two different difficulties.

The point of this chapter is to establish what stands in someone's way before deciding what to do next. A shortage of time may not be solved by pressure. Help that was never promised should not be treated as a broken commitment.

# 1 A story: three refusals to lend a knife need different responses

While setting up a market, a volunteer named A Qiao discovered that they were short of a craft knife and went to borrow one from a nearby stall.

The first stallholder held up the display labels they were working on. “This is my only one, and I’m using it.”

The second also refused. They pointed to a damaged part of the knife and said they were worried someone would hurt their hand if they lent it out.

The third was most definite. “I’ve lent things before and still couldn’t find them when it was time to pack up. I don’t lend tools anymore.”

A Qiao returned empty-handed and complained to a friend: “People here are so stingy.”

The friend asked, “What are you going to do now?”

A Qiao had intended to go back and ask more nicely. As he was about to say so, he realized that the three situations were not the same. The first stallholder might finish using their knife in a while. The second knife would not be safe to use even if A Qiao borrowed it. The third person was worried that once the knife left his stall, it would not come back.

The same appeal—“Please help me out”—could not solve all three problems.

# 2 Understanding the reason helps you choose a useful response

## The behavior is visible; the constraints may not be

A Qiao heard the stallholders say no. But what a knife would be needed for next, or what had happened when tools were lent before, was not all visible. If he focused only on the refusal, he could easily use someone's character to explain circumstances he did not yet understand.

Gilbert and Malone discuss "correspondence bias": treating behavior that could be explained by circumstances as evidence of a stable disposition. One cause they examine is that the conditions influencing behavior may be out of the observer's sight, or even known only to the person acting. [1] "They don't want to help" can therefore sound like an explanation while merely replacing missing background with an evaluation of the person.

For A Qiao, the practical reminder is that seeing a refusal does not mean seeing all the reasons for it. Leaving room for what he does not yet know gives him a reason to inquire further, rather than reducing the problem to "Why won't they be more generous?"

## Hearing a reason is not the same as taking it into account

Yet A Qiao was not completely uninformed. The stallholders had already explained that the knife was in use, that it was damaged, and that it was no longer available to borrow. He still called all

three stingy. What he needed was no longer simply to hear more reasons. He needed to ask whether those reasons undermined his original accusation.

In an experiment by Gilbert and Osborne, university students watched the same silent video of a woman who appeared nervous. Captions indicated either that she was discussing anxiety-provoking topics or that she was discussing ordinary ones. Some participants also had to remember a sequence of numbers. Although those with the memory task remembered the topics, their initial judgments of whether she was generally anxious did not adjust to the topics as those of the other group did. [2] Knowing the background and using it to reconsider a person can indeed be different things.

These materials suggest a tendency worth noticing: an initial impression of a person may form quickly, while taking the circumstances into account requires further attention. When our minds are occupied with something else, we may have heard an explanation without changing our judgment.

Applied to A Qiao's situation, the first stallholder had their own setup work to do. The second had explained why the tool was unsafe. The third did not want to bear the trouble of trying to recover it. Once those specifics were considered, "They're all stingy" was no longer an equally suitable explanation for the three refusals.

## Do not turn every practical problem into an argument about attitude

A Qiao could ask the first stallholder roughly when they would finish, then decide whether to wait. For the second, he needed to find an undamaged tool elsewhere. He could ask the third whether an agreed return time and place would help. If the person still did not want to lend it, A Qiao could make another arrangement.

These are practical differences. A damaged tool is not a lack of enthusiasm. A tool in use will not instantly become available because the request is phrased more pleasantly. Insisting that someone “be more generous” leads to an argument about who is good enough without answering where the knife will come from.

This does not require A Qiao to believe every reason offered. If the first stallholder finished using the knife but still refused, he would need to accept that the earlier reason was incomplete or that the person had changed his mind. He could ask once more or stop trying to borrow it. He should not invent reasons on someone else’s behalf to preserve the belief that the person really wants to help.

## Ask only about what affects the arrangement

Understanding a reason also means knowing where to stop asking.

To borrow a knife, A Qiao needs to know whether it is available, when he can use it, and how to return it. The third stallholder has no obligation to describe every previous loss, much less hand over private chat records to prove that he is entitled to refuse.

“I don’t lend my tools” may sometimes be enough. A Qiao needs to solve the setup problem; he does not need to uncover the person’s entire inner life first.

Even if agreeing on a return arrangement resulted in borrowing the knife, he could report only that it was lent after that arrangement was made. Familiarity, availability, and trust may all change during a single interaction. One success would not establish that he had found a way to make everyone agree.

## 3 A story: does an emergency mean the people left waiting were not inconvenienced?

When the market ended, A Qiao encountered a harder situation.

The volunteers were originally due to arrive at eight in the evening to dismantle the displays. That afternoon, the venue changed their access time to ten and notified only the event coordinator, Zhao Wei. She was caring for a family member who had suddenly become ill, did not see the message promptly, and did not pass the change on.

At eight, A Qiao and the other volunteers were already there. They put their tools by the entrance and asked around before learning that they could not yet go inside. By the time they could start, two extra hours had passed.

Zhao Wei later explained the family emergency. Until then, A Qiao had thought she knew the time had changed and deliberately failed to tell them. Now he knew she had not seen the venue’s notification promptly. He could no longer say that she had knowingly ignored everyone after learning of the change.

But he was still upset. “I know it wasn’t deliberate. We really did wait here for two hours, though.”

Zhao Wei did not end the discussion with “I had my reasons.” She shared the venue contact and the latest notice in the group chat and discussed how to redistribute the dismantling work. The lost time could not be recovered. Someone still had to do the remaining work.

The next day, they reviewed the notification process. The venue had contacted only Zhao Wei; when the others could not get a reply from her, they did not know whom else to ask. They then agreed that time changes would be sent to two contacts simultaneously and that participants would know where to find the latest arrangements.

This did not erase that night’s waiting, nor did it require Zhao Wei to be constantly available during every future emergency. It gave everyone something specific they could change.

## 4 Once the reasons are clear, make responsibility specific too

The difference between borrowing a knife and dismantling the exhibition matters here.

The stallholders had never agreed to lend A Qiao a knife. Refusing was not, in itself, breaking a commitment. Zhao Wei had taken responsibility for event notifications. When a message did not reach people and affected their arrangements, she needed to explain what had happened and participate in dealing with the consequences.

The extent of responsibility still depends on what she could do at the time. Having the means to pass on a message but forgetting is different from suddenly losing the ability to communicate. Calling both “irresponsibility” can unfairly blame someone and conceal what should change next time.

After understanding a cause, we can withdraw an unfounded accusation while retaining expectations about an actual omission. A Qiao no longer says Zhao Wei deliberately left everyone waiting; he can still ask for a backup contact in future. Zhao Wei can explain the difficulty she faced that day while also communicating the changes she now knows about and cooperating with a revised notification process.

Conversely, if someone had the time and the means, explicitly agreed to a task, and did not do it, it is appropriate to ask for an explanation and corrective action concerning that particular failure. Considering circumstances does not mean endlessly searching for excuses for every mistake.

We also need to check whether our demands are feasible. Asking someone without internet access to follow a group chat in real time, or asking someone without decision-making authority to guarantee when the venue will open, simply sets up the same argument for next time.

## Return to what needs doing

When faced with a behavior, do not rush to decide what sort of person you are dealing with. Fill in circumstances you have not seen and take the reasons you have already heard seriously, ask-

ing where your original judgment was mistaken. Then look at what the person agreed to, what means they had, and which step they actually failed to complete.

If a tool is missing, find a tool. If time is short, rearrange the work. If an existing commitment has not been fulfilled, explain the specific omission and the remedy needed. When someone refuses something they had not undertaken, leave them room to refuse.

Understanding others should ultimately help us do less useless persuading and solve one more practical problem.

**Source notes** [1] Daniel T. Gilbert and Patrick S. Malone (1995), author-hosted copy of *The Correspondence Bias*, R11. In addition to the opening page, consultation covered selected passages on awareness of circumstances on PDF pages 5–6 and correction mechanisms and limitations on pages 9–10. The full 18 pages and cited studies were not comprehensively checked. This is a theoretical review, not a law that everyone always judges character first. [2] Daniel T. Gilbert and Randall E. Osborne (1989), author-hosted copy of *Thinking Backward*, R15. Consultation covered the abstract and relevant passages from Experiment 1's methods and results on PDF pages 3–7. The remaining experiments and original data were not systematically checked. A video-viewing and number-memory task involving female students at one university does not directly establish the causes of A Qiao's reactions, prove that being busy necessarily causes misjudgment, or show that this chapter's questions are effective. The treatment of borrowing, notifications, privacy, and responsibility is this book's synthesis and value choice. The stories are not research evidence. See References and Scope of Consultation.

**Chapter 5**

# How Relationships, Identity, and Culture Shape Expectations

*The characters, community event, and dialogue in this chapter are original fiction. They do not represent an ethnic group and are not drawn from readers' experiences.*

Why can people still feel disappointed after you have done everything you agreed to do?

Because they may care about more than whether the task was completed. They may also be reading your response as an answer to another question: when we need something, are you willing to care about us? "I don't have time today" may be a statement about availability but be heard as "Our relationship isn't that important."

This chapter examines how people read help and refusal as signals about a relationship. When expectations remain unspoken, both parties can feel the other is unreasonable: one is explaining how much they can do, while the other is asking whether the relationship still means anything. To move beyond that dispute, first understand what matters to each person, then check what was actually agreed for this occasion.

# 1 A story: she finished helping, so why did she still seem to owe everyone something?

A community was organizing a secondhand-goods exchange. The organizer, Amin, asked her neighbor Yanan to check the bilingual signs. Yanan agreed to review the translations once before the event began. At ten, she sent the corrected file, gathered her things, and prepared to leave for a gathering of her own.

Amin stopped her at the entrance. “People here still need interpreting. We all thought you’d stay. Aren’t you the one who knows both languages best?”

Participants had already begun arriving with items to register. Some details needed to be clarified individually. Amin could not find another bilingual helper and hoped Yanan would stay until at least two in the afternoon.

For Amin, the event’s smooth running was at stake. For Yanan, this meant four hours she had not planned to give.

“I only agreed to check the signs,” Yanan said.

Another organizer added, “We’re all part of the same community. There’s no need to draw such a sharp line.”

Yanan stopped explaining, picked up her bag, and left. She had come to do something she willingly agreed to, yet departed feeling as if she owed everyone something. Looking at the people waiting by the entrance, Amin thought Yanan cared only about her own plans and would not do a little more to help.

After the event, they discussed it again.

Amin said, “Usually, when someone sees we’re short of help, they pitch in. I’m not trying to count your hours. I just felt: how could you leave when everyone was so busy?”

Yanan heard the disappointment and explained her own concern. “I wanted to help, which is why I agreed to check the wording. But if showing up means I’ve also taken on interpreting, I’ll have to set aside a whole block of time whenever I want to attend an event.”

Amin wanted Yanan to know that neighbors helping one another mattered to her. Yanan wanted to remain free to show up simply as a neighbor, without first having to take on a job every time.

When organizing the next event, Amin listed on-site interpreting as a separate role, with the required hours specified. Yanan agreed to check the wording again but did not take the on-site role. That slot remained empty, and Amin still had to find someone.

The staffing shortage did not disappear because they had talked. Amin still found the preparation difficult, and Yanan did not offer all her time. But they had at least begun discussing which work remained uncovered instead of merely arguing about who cared enough about the community.

## 2 What else are people trying to establish when they ask for help?

The “I only agreed to check the signs” that Amin heard was not on the same level as the message Yanan intended.

Yanan was saying that she had completed the task. Amin was thinking: since we are neighbors who look out for each other, why should I have to make another request when help is needed now? She expected more than a translation. She expected someone who saw a need to stay without being asked.

That expectation has a context. In relationships where mutual care matters, helping often means: I noticed what you need and am willing to do something for you. It lets people feel they are not facing difficulties alone and do not have to offer an equivalent return every time. If someone then emphasizes, “I’ve done my part,” the other person may feel that the relationship is more distant than they thought.

Clark and Mills distinguished relationship norms focused on responding to each other’s needs from those focused on corresponding returns. Their early experiments with university students found that how receiving repayment after giving help affected liking for another person varied with the relationship expectations induced in the experiment. [1] People respond not only to how much they receive but also to what the action seems to say about the relationship the other person wants.

Seen through this lens, Amin’s disappointment is not only “We’re short of an interpreter.” It also involves “Do you see yourself as one of us?” This helps explain why she feels that discussing the task’s scope is not enough. It does not establish that Yanan therefore owes her four hours.

Yanan also wanted to support the community; that was why she agreed to check the translation. Clarifying her available time does not mean she wants to turn every act of help into a transac-

tion. Both people may genuinely value mutual support yet disagree about how much more should be done this time and whether another request is necessary.

To understand disappointment within a relationship, then, separate two things: hoping for someone's care and having their agreement to a particular task. The first can be expressed seriously. The second requires an actual agreement. When they are confused, people can start demanding that others prove the relationship still matters by continually accepting additional work.

## 3 Why can a skill become a permanent role?

When Amin urgently needed an interpreter, the most visible part of Yanan's identity was "one of us who speaks both languages." Yanan could do the work and belonged to the community, so asking her to fill the gap seemed only natural to the organizer.

But Yanan was also thinking about her friends, the gathering already arranged, and how she would participate in future community activities. The organizer saw a solution in her without also seeing that she needed to make time for other relationships.

Amartya Sen challenges the reduction of a person to a single identity, emphasizing multiple affiliations and the room to choose among them. [2] This book draws on that perspective to suggest that an identity can help us decide whom to ask, but cannot accept the request on that person's behalf.

This is a change worth watching in familiar relationships. At first, "She knows how to do this" is a reason to seek help. If no one keeps asking for her agreement, it may become "This is her job

anyway." One voluntary contribution gradually becomes an ongoing role. Refusing then seems to require an explanation of why she is no longer willing.

The effects of that expanded role reach beyond one missed gathering. Yanan may begin wondering whether to attend at all, because she does not know how many unstated duties one appearance will bring. A relationship intended to be sustained through mutual help may end up making it harder for a willing participant to come close.

The more useful a skill is, the more worthwhile it is to ask how the person wants to participate. Otherwise, an argument that appears to concern generosity may really be about whether someone can still decide in what capacity, and for how much time, to take part.

## 4 Cultural background can explain an expectation's origins, but cannot agree on someone's behalf

Some cooperative habits develop through long association. Some people are used to finishing the group's work before considering their own convenience. Others are used to agreeing on scope first, believing this avoids burdening anyone. Each approach works in a familiar circle, and people may assume that someone elsewhere should understand it too.

In *From the Soil* (*Xiangtu Zhongguo*), Fei Xiaotong discusses the relational structure of traditional grassroots Chinese society. The "differential mode of association" is an important theme. [3] Such

historical analysis draws attention to how degrees of closeness help shape expectations. Yet Amin and Yanan's disagreement still needs to be understood through this particular collaboration. Nationality, names, or accents cannot assign either person a character.

They might have grown up in the same place but learned different approaches in different organizations. Even similar habits do not mean they have the same time or responsibilities on this occasion.

Cultural knowledge is useful here because it suggests another possibility to consider: does the other person regard filling in at short notice as an unspoken understanding among familiar people? The next step is still to ask the person, rather than announcing, "People from your background are like that." Respecting a background also means allowing someone not to behave according to our understanding of it.

## 5 Make both your care and what you can do this time clear

Repeating only "I never agreed to that" may leave Amin's disappointment about the relationship unanswered. Emphasizing only "I do care about the community" may leave the scope of the original task unclear. Both meanings deserve to be heard. Neither requires accepting additional work in order to be expressed.

Yanan could respond: “I want to take part, and I’ve finished checking the wording. I can’t stay until two today. Please ask me about specific hours in advance if you need interpreting next time. When I’m free to come to an event, I’d also like to be able to attend simply as a participant.”

This explains how she is willing to remain involved and what she cannot take on now. She does not need to disclose the private details of her gathering to prove her plans are more important than the event.

Amin could also say: “I treated filling in at short notice as something we all understood, and I didn’t ask separately about your time. We’re still short of help, so I need to keep arranging it.”

Having willingly done extra work several times before does not automatically mean agreeing this time. Conversely, if Yanan had explicitly committed to being there throughout and then needed to leave, she would need to explain the change, its effects, and the handover as early as possible. A relationship cannot quietly enlarge a commitment, and discussion of identity cannot erase a commitment actually made.

If someone continues to use humiliation or exclusion to demand proof of care, she can stop arguing and decide whether to remain involved. Wanting to sustain a relationship and being required to accept every task it proposes are different choices.

To return to the opening question: finishing the agreed work can still disappoint someone because they carry an unspoken expectation about the relationship. Understanding that expectation may reduce mutual accusation. Whether to stay, and for how long, still needs discussion.

For mutual help to continue, there also needs to be room for this reply: “I care about you, but this is as much as I can do today.”

**Source notes** [1] Margaret S. Clark and Judson Mills (1979), R16, original paper hosted by the author’s laboratory. Consultation covered the abstract, conceptual definitions, Experiment 1’s methods and results, and relevant general-discussion passages on PDF pages 1–5 and 12. The full 13 pages were not read, and Experiment 2’s methods and the original data were not checked. Experiments on specific initial interactions do not establish the psychological causes of the fictional community members’ actions or equate task boundaries with transactional relationships. [2] P04, description of Sen’s book. The material used remains limited to the themes of multiple affiliations and choice in the public description. These are philosophical arguments; the full book was not read. [3] P05, The Commercial Press’s description and contents for *Xiangtu Zhongguo*. The scope of consultation has not expanded; historical material is not treated as proof of contemporary group behavior. The discussion of relationship signals, expanding roles, and possible actions is this book’s interpretation and value choice, not a verified universal law of human nature or evidence of teaching effectiveness. See References and Scope of Consultation.

**Chapter 6**

# How Interests, Resources, and Rules Shape Choices

*The characters, community, booking system, and proposed charges in this chapter are original fiction, not findings from a study of real governance.*

When competing for a resource, we can easily see “This benefits me” as “This is how it ought to be allocated.” That need not be a deliberate attempt to take advantage. Sometimes the standard we sincerely regard as fair has already tilted in our favor.

Interests concern more than getting a little extra money. They include being able to organize our time, carry out what we promised, and avoid additional work. When our own arrangements are involved, we may cling to the arguments that support us and see another person’s dissatisfaction as unreasonable.

A dispute over shared resources therefore cannot be settled simply by asking who is more generous. We also need to examine what each party is protecting, whom the same rule makes things easier for, and whose work it leaves behind. Otherwise, even a group of more agreeable people may find the original arrangements repeatedly producing conflict.

## A story: no one jumped the queue, so why was there an argument?

A community had an activity room that could be used for classes, rehearsals, and book groups. Saturday afternoons from two to five were the most popular slot. The manager introduced a simple system: at noon every Monday, the newly available Saturday slots would be posted in the group chat. Whoever replied first could reserve one.

For three consecutive weekends, Xu Lan's book group secured the afternoon. She could check her phone between tasks at work and knew she had to respond as soon as the message appeared.

Qiu Lin, from the dance group, was often on duty at that time. By the time he saw the message after work, the room was taken. After missing out for the third time, he wrote in the group chat: "Some people only think of themselves and take all the good slots."

Xu Lan replied, "I applied according to the rules every time. I didn't jump the queue. Why is this my fault?"

She did not want to lose the afternoon either. The members worked during the week, so that weekend time was relatively easy to arrange. A different slot would mean asking everyone again. To her, this was not something she could simply give away by being a little more generous.

Both groups wanted the room from two to five. Reading and dance practice could not take place in the same room simultaneously.

While they argued, Uncle Tao, who kept the keys and tidied the room, said nothing. At five on Saturday, the participants left, while he was still putting the tables and chairs back and clearing the rubbish they had left.

The manager brought several people together, initially intending to persuade Xu Lan to give up one slot. Only when they compared the booking messages with everyone's working hours did he see that Xu Lan could respond promptly while Qiu Lin often could not see a new message. Both could submit requests, but their actual chances of securing a slot were very different.

Uncle Tao asked, "You all say you'll finish at five. Who clears this up afterward?"

The rules had specified only who could book first. They did not say when users had to restore the room or ask whether Uncle Tao could stay late each time. Because he had the keys, the closing work had kept falling to him.

Someone suggested charging people who failed to clean up. Uncle Tao asked, "If you charge them, does that mean they can leave it to me? I'd like to go home on time too."

By then, asking who was more considerate could no longer answer the problem before them.

They collected the next round of requests together. Only these two groups had applied for the four Saturday afternoons in the following month. They decided to alternate, giving each group two sessions instead of relying only on who could catch the group message. If a group could not attend, it had to release its slot promptly and let the other group know.

Users also had to include closing tasks in their booked time: reserve the final twenty minutes for putting the furniture back and clearing the rubbish, then hand over to Uncle Tao. After trying it, they would see whether twenty minutes was enough. They did not decide on charges at that meeting.

Qiu Lin still wanted weekly rehearsals, and Xu Lan did not want fewer book-group meetings. Both groups had to change their plans. Activities would also have to end twenty minutes earlier to allow for clearing up. The trial arrangement did not eliminate every disagreement, but it made explicit which two sessions each group would give up in the next round and who would restore the room.

## Why does the argument for fairness so easily take our own side?

Xu Lan argued that she had followed the booking rules. Qiu Lin argued that everyone should have a chance. Both points had merit, and both happened to protect the speaker's needs.

For Xu Lan, first come, first served allowed her to notify members early and avoid repeated changes. What she saw was that she had applied promptly without displacing anyone who already held a booking. Qiu Lin had missed out three times running. His main concern was: if he could not check his phone at work, would his turn ever come?

The two did not merely have different needs for the same room. They were also judging fairness from different positions. Xu Lan could easily treat "I didn't break the rules" as the end of the dis-

cussion. Qiu Lin could treat “I didn’t get a chance” as proof that Xu Lan was selfish. Before anyone could examine whether the rule was suitable, the question had become who was mistreating whom.

Babcock and colleagues asked participants to read the same legal case and take the role of either a claimant or a defendant. Some learned their role before reading the material. Others read it and judged a fair settlement before learning which side they would take. Those who knew their side in advance made fairness judgments more favorable to themselves, and the parties were less likely to reach agreement. [1] Interests may affect how we understand facts, not merely the terms we finally propose.

Why might that happen? A contested issue often admits more than one plausible argument. What we hope to retain can make us give more weight to the parts that support it: Xu Lan kept thinking about applying on time; Qiu Lin kept thinking about being unable to check messages at work. We do not necessarily decide “I will be selfish” and then seek excuses. We may instead become increasingly convinced that what we insist on is precisely what fairness requires. This is the book’s perspective on their dispute, not a diagnosis of their inner states.

Recognizing this does not require concluding, “Both are self-interested, so believe neither.” Instead, state the principles fully: what is first come, first served intended to achieve? What counts as having an opportunity to apply? How long may one group occupy the slot consecutively? When proposing an arrangement, explain

what it asks others to give up. This makes it possible to discuss the allocation's purpose, rather than allowing one person's "I'm right" to overpower the other's.

## How rules make some choices easier

The original system gave Xu Lan a straightforward route: a message appeared, and a reply secured the time. To do the same, Qiu Lin had to respond promptly while on duty. A rule saying "Anyone may apply" does not mean everyone pays the same cost to do so.

That explains why simply urging Qiu Lin to be more proactive would not solve the problem. The groups were competing for access to the activity room, but the system effectively selected for who could respond immediately at noon on Monday. Xu Lan's following the rule and the rule's needing revision could both be true.

Uncle Tao faced a different arrangement. After five, the users were gone. For them, the activity was over; for him, the work was not. The old system did not require users to set aside their own activity time for closing tasks, so they could spend the full three hours on what they wanted. The room would still be restored. Uncle Tao simply bore the cost.

Without changing that, repeated appeals to consider Uncle Tao would do little to tell him when he could expect to go home on time. Including clearing up within the reservation required users

to choose between continuing their activity a little longer and restoring the room on time. Here, the rule changed who had to plan for the labor. It did not suddenly make anyone more caring.

Ostrom's work on the governance of common resources considers different arrangements and the conditions under which they succeed or fail. [2] Drawing on that perspective, this chapter brings both applicants and those implementing the arrangements into the discussion: who gets access matters, and the work needed to maintain it should also be explained by the people actually doing it. Not competing for the room does not make the allocation irrelevant to the person cleaning it.

## Why a fine may be understood as permission

"Charge anyone who doesn't clean up" appears simply to make leaving rubbish more expensive. But people may read another message into the rule: now that a price is listed, does paying it mean they no longer need to clear up?

Gneezy and Rustichini conducted a field study in Israeli day-care centers. Some centers introduced a fine for parents who collected their children late. Lateness increased instead, and did not return to its earlier level after the fine was removed. The authors proposed one possible explanation: behavior previously understood as inconveniencing teachers might have been reinterpreted as buying extra care. The paper also considered explanations involving information the fine conveyed about consequences. The data did not fully distinguish these explanations. [3]

The study reminds us that people may do more than calculate an amount. They may also infer what a rule now permits. If a manager intends a charge only as a deterrent but does not explain whether responsibility has changed, users and managers may read different arrangements into the same sentence.

Back in the activity room, Uncle Tao's questions were specific: who would receive the money, and had anyone actually agreed to take on the cleaning? If the manager collected the money but Uncle Tao still had to stay, the payment would not give him back his time to go home.

The community could discuss a paid cleaning service or continue to require users to restore the room themselves. These involve different staffing and responsibilities, which need to be made clear separately. Holding the keys did not mean Uncle Tao had already accepted all additional work.

## Understanding interests does not remove trade-offs or responsibility

*Getting to Yes* advocates attending to the interests behind demands rather than remaining fixed on stated positions. [4] Asking why the two groups needed Saturday afternoon might reveal another workable time, or establish that some activities need not take place every week. Understanding needs can indeed open up alternatives.

But in this story, both groups wanted the same room every week, and reading and dance practice could not happen there together. Knowing why the slot mattered did not create another afternoon.

Alternating two sessions each gave Qiu Lin an opportunity, while requiring both groups to move from the weekly sessions they wanted to two sessions in four weeks. Ending activities twenty minutes earlier returned the work previously falling to Uncle Tao to the users' own schedules. If someone was unhappy, it did not necessarily mean they had failed to understand. They might genuinely be giving up a convenience.

When discussing a proposal, acknowledging those costs is more honest than announcing that nobody loses anything. Someone can accept that an arrangement is fairer and still regret what they lose. They should not have to look pleased before being considered cooperative.

After the trial, the actual records also need examining. Can the groups plan ahead? Are released slots communicated? Are the last twenty minutes enough for clearing up? All require checking in practice. Alternating over four weeks and reserving twenty minutes were arrangements these people chose to try, not an optimal system established by appearing in a story.

If there is enough time and responsibility is clear but a group repeatedly fails to clean up, the specific failure should be addressed according to the prior agreement. Seeing how rules influence behavior does not release people from commitments. But if clearing up really cannot be completed in time, the arrangements need changing rather than simply blaming users for a lack of consideration.

Returning to the chapter's question: interests may lead us to give more weight to reasons favorable to ourselves. Resources determine which wishes cannot all be fulfilled. Rules influence who can more easily do something, who bears the cost, and what people believe they are permitted to do.

Next time a dispute arises, ask more than "Why won't that person give way?" Ask whether your standard of fairness has considered only your own needs, and whether your convenience has long depended on someone else doing a little more. Making those two matters explicit gives you a better chance of jointly choosing an arrangement people can carry out and are willing to bear.

**Source notes** [1] R17, Babcock and colleagues (1995), author-hosted original paper. All seven pages were read, with particular attention to the experiment, results, and conclusions on printed pages 1338–1342. The data were not recalculated and the cited studies were not independently checked. For R18, the publication page for the 2019 replication, consultation was limited to the abstract and publicly available introduction excerpts appearing in search results. The effect was in the same direction but weaker; the original finding should not be presented as having a fixed magnitude or universal application. [2] P06, publisher's description and contents for *Governing the Commons*. Consultation remains limited to those materials, not close reading of the book or validation of the activity-room arrangement. [3] R12, author-hosted version of *A Fine Is a Price*. Relevant passages on methods, results in the text, the social-norm explanation, and conclusions were consulted; the full 18 pages, statistical appendices, and original data were not comprehensively checked. Observed outcomes are distinguished from the authors' proposed mechanisms; the study does not establish that all fines are ineffective. [4] P03, publisher's description of *Getting to Yes*. Use remains limited to the publicly described method's main points. The analysis of roles in the activity room and the recommendations for action are this book's synthesis and value choices. The story does not prove the research, and the research does not diagnose the fictional characters. See References and Scope of Consultation.

Part III

# Showing Care in Everyday Life

**Chapter 7**

# Why Someone May Feel Unheard When We Try to Help

*The bookshop, workplace complaint, and interview preparation in this chapter are fictional. They do not describe the author's or readers' experiences or research cases.*

Sometimes the advice is sound, but it arrives too soon. Someone is still telling us how painful an experience has been, and we are already organizing their next steps. What reaches them may not feel like care. It may feel like another demand: please get better quickly, so I can know that I have helped.

This mismatch need not come from indifference. Hearing about another person's difficulties can make the helper uneasy too. Finding a solution gives us something to do. Sitting with someone and acknowledging that there is no good answer right now can leave us feeling more helpless. Our own urgency may then decide the direction of the conversation before we understand what the other person needs.

**Care begins by matching the help to what someone wants at this moment. One person wants to finish telling a story; another needs help comparing options; another does not want to talk yet. Good intentions alone do not give us the right to choose for them.**

## She had not asked her friend to save the bookshop

Ye Sheng and her business partner had run a neighborhood bookshop for nine years. They had decided to end the lease on the last Sunday of the month, and had made arrangements for refunds and the remaining books. At 8:10 one evening, she called He Yuan. Someone had come that day to measure the storefront before taking down the sign, she told him. She had stood outside for a long time.

He Yuan immediately thought of online sales and cheaper premises. Each time he proposed something, Ye Sheng explained that they had already discussed it. When he said that she had to look ahead, she finally said what she had wanted to say: she did not really want to close up alone that evening.

He Yuan had heard a question about how to keep the business going. Ye Sheng wanted to talk about the end of a life in which, for nine years, she had opened the doors, arranged the books, and greeted regular customers every day. A decision can make sense without making the goodbye any less sad.

He stopped proposing solutions and asked what she had been thinking about as she stood outside. Ye Sheng talked about the regulars. She also admitted to feeling a little relieved that she would no longer have to worry about the rent every month. Both feelings were there; she did not need to decide which was the right one. He Yuan told her that he had to leave at 8:30 to pick up his child, and could listen until then.

The call did not produce a new business plan. Ye Sheng finished her tea and felt that she had finally said what had happened that day. Near the end of the call, she asked a separate question: could he come on Sunday to help sort books to give away for an hour? He checked his plans and agreed. That was a specific request for help that emerged later, not a task the entire conversation had needed to accomplish from the start.

The person offering advice may focus on how many solutions they have suggested. The person speaking may care more about whether the part they most wanted to express has been heard. If we keep steering the conversation back to the future, they must also explain why someone who has already decided to stop is still entitled to feel sad.

In an experiment on initial interactions, Weger and colleagues found that people receiving active-listening responses felt more understood. However, conversation satisfaction did not differ significantly between active listening and advice.[1] The study supports paying attention to whether someone feels understood; it does not establish that advice is always inferior to listening. What needs checking is the request in this conversation, not a universal ranking of ways to help.

## Hearing someone's hurt does not mean endorsing their assumptions

Chen Xu had spent two evenings preparing a project presentation. He then learned that the meeting had been brought forward, but he had not received the updated notice. Complaining to

his friend Wang Cheng, he said that his supervisor had deliberately tried to embarrass him. He was considering posting an accusation in the work group chat.

Wang Cheng wanted to show that he was on his friend's side and nearly agreed that the supervisor was targeting him. But all they knew at that point was that the meeting time had changed and Chen Xu had not received the notice. They did not yet know where the notification had gone astray.

Wang Cheng first listened to how Chen Xu had prepared over those two evenings, and how awkward it had felt to arrive and discover that the presentations were already over. Chen Xu did not need to prove malicious intent before his disappointment deserved a serious hearing. As for making a public accusation, Wang Cheng did not forward it for him. He suggested checking what had happened to the notification before deciding how to respond.

This was not a way of pushing the hurt back onto Chen Xu or telling him not to be angry. The feelings had already occurred; their cause still needed checking. Whether to endorse the proposed next action was a further question. Keeping these three levels separate avoids a false choice between agreeing with every accusation and immediately arguing against the person's feelings.

Sometimes people show closeness by agreeing with another person's judgment, because they fear that saying "I don't know yet" will sound unsupportive. That is this book's interpretation of one kind of interaction. But companionship does not require us to

manufacture certainty. We can recognize genuine disappointment without vouching for unverified motives or supporting behavior that humiliates someone else.

BayNVC's account of empathy emphasizes trying to understand feelings and needs while allowing the other person to correct us. We do not have to guess correctly.[2] Rather than saying, "I know exactly what this is—you're afraid of failing," we can follow what the person has actually said. If Chen Xu says that what matters most is that his effort never had a chance to be seen, we can explore that meaning rather than insist on our earlier summary of his experience.

## When someone explicitly asks for advice, advice can be care

Shen Zhou had an interview at six in the evening. At 5:20, he sent his friend Xu Han two sections of his self-introduction and asked her to help cut them to three minutes. Xu Han could hear that he was nervous. She wanted to reassure him first, and asked whether he had been worrying all along that he would not find a suitable job.

Shen Zhou explained that he wanted to revise these two sections now and did not really want to discuss the rest. Xu Han turned to the text. She pointed out that the same experience appeared twice and helped him keep the material relevant to this position. She also made clear that she had a remote handover at 5:40: she could help for these twenty minutes, but could not redo all his material for him.

When the time came, they stopped. Xu Han did not require him to disclose his worries before his response could count as accepting care. Nor did she promise that the revision would guarantee success in the interview. The practical help matched his explicit request. There was no need to turn the conversation into an opportunity to unburden himself.

Understanding the need first does not mean solemnly asking “Do you need listening or advice?” every time. If the request is already clear, respond to it attentively. If it is unclear, ask whether the person would like to talk first or work through possible solutions together. Having asked, we must accept the answer—including wanting to be alone for a while, not wanting to discuss private matters, or needing just one limited piece of help.

Where there is a clear danger or something requiring immediate attention, take the necessary action first. Do not delay a real need to complete a listening routine. Helpers also have limits on their time and abilities; they can suggest another time or decline. Listening until we become impatient and then blaming someone for talking too much does not make our companionship more honest.

## Place your care within what the person is experiencing

Listening attentively does not require repeating every sentence or constantly proving how well we understand. Staying with a specific experience and allowing our understanding to be corrected brings us closer to the person than a string of automatic responses.

Sadness that does not disappear on the spot does not necessarily mean that the conversation failed. Someone's willingness to hear one suggestion does not mean that we may organize every future decision. We can instead ask whether we understood what they actually wanted to say, provided the help we agreed to within its limits, and avoided pretending to know what we still did not know.

Why might someone feel unheard when we are trying to help? Sometimes we focus entirely on how a situation could change and miss what it means to that person. Find out what kind of help is needed this time, then direct your goodwill there. Some care is delivered through solutions. Some begins with not rushing someone to finish speaking.

**Source notes** [1] R19, Weger et al. (2014), original abstract in UCF's institutional record. The abstract and bibliographic record were consulted; the full text and original data were not read. Feeling understood and conversation satisfaction in initial interactions are distinct outcomes. The findings are not extended here to long-term friendships or therapeutic effects. [2] P02, BayNVC's practical guide, especially Empathy, Observations, Feelings, and Requests. This is a practice method, not a measure of mind reading. The helper's helplessness, a friend's eagerness to agree in order to show support, and the three specific choices in this chapter are this book's interpretations and fictional applications. See the book's reference list for bibliographic details and reading scope.

**Chapter 8**

# How to Show Care, Express Genuine Appreciation, and Give Feedback

*The onboarding, choir, and sports-team stories in this chapter are fictional. They do not depict real organizations or the author's or readers' experiences.*

You may know how much someone has helped, while all they hear from you is what they have done badly. Familiar contributions fade into the background; the mistake in front of us demands an immediate response. Over time, care may remain very real in our own minds without ever reaching the other person.

Another obstacle is our fear that saying thank you will sound awkward or overly formal, so we wait for a better opportunity. But the other person cannot directly see our appreciation. Waiting for perfect words can keep genuine gratitude permanently unspoken.

**When thanking someone, say what you noticed. When giving feedback, explain what needs to change. A mistake does not erase a contribution, and a compliment cannot commit someone to future work.**

## You do not need beautiful words before you can say thank you

When Xu Mo started his new job, Wen Ning spent half a day showing him how the order ledger worked. She did more than send him the old spreadsheet: she pointed out which notes affected the next day's shipments. A few weeks later, Xu Mo handled a batch of orders on his own and used her explanation to spot an omission. He wanted to thank her, but felt that sending a separate message about it would seem unnecessarily formal.

The sentence sat in his message box for two days. When he finally sent it, he did not write at length. He explained how the notes she had clarified helped him avoid missing a shipment, and thanked her for her time. Only then did Wen Ning learn that those details had proved useful later.

This was not elaborate praise. Xu Mo did not present Wen Ning as someone who never made mistakes, and did not ask her to help with the next batch. He simply expressed something he already knew about her help that she might not have known herself.

In gratitude-letter experiments, Kumar and Epley found that people expressing gratitude underestimated recipients' positive feelings and overestimated awkwardness.[1] This reminds us that worrying about our wording is not reliable evidence that someone does not want to hear our thanks. But findings about gratitude letters cannot predict how every individual will respond to public praise.

There is no need, then, to wait for a beautiful sentence. Start with how a specific contribution helped you, and choose an appropriate way to express it for the relationship and occasion. Someone who dislikes being singled out publicly can be thanked in private. Someone who would rather acknowledge it lightly need not give an equally solemn response. Sincerity is not measured by the scale of the occasion.

## When pointing out a mistake, make the task clear first

A twenty-four-member amateur choir was due to perform at a community event in six weeks. Lu Ning spent three evenings, about an hour each, organizing rehearsal recordings with page numbers and starting points. The conductor, Cheng Zheng, noticed that the second section still used the old version. In the full group chat, she said that Lu Ning had “used the wrong one again” and told whoever prepared the materials to be more careful.

There was no confirmed previous mistake of the same kind to justify “again.” When Cheng Zheng later checked the messages, she discovered that Wednesday’s new version had gone only to a smaller chat for the conductor and section leaders. Lu Ning had never received it. Cheng Zheng first clarified the missed notification and misplaced blame in the original chat, asked everyone to stop using the old recording for now, and then discussed the correction privately.

Only the final forty seconds of the second section needed changing; the rest remained usable. Cheng Zheng supplied the new version and took responsibility for checking the result. Lu Ning

confirmed that she could rerecord it on Saturday evening, in time for Sunday's rehearsal. The problem was neither concealed by saying "She's actually very conscientious" nor left with her under the vague instruction to "be more careful."

When people hear broad criticism, they may first try to prove that they are not careless. The specific repair can recede into the background. Cheng Zheng wanted to call attention to the task, but an unverified "again" and a judgment with implications about character directed attention toward Lu Ning's overall performance instead.

Kluger and DeNisi's meta-analysis of feedback showed that feedback does not always improve performance. They proposed a preliminary explanation: feedback may direct people's attention toward how to perform a task, or toward how they themselves are being evaluated.[2] This mechanism is not a fully established formula for what to say, but it offers a useful check: after we have spoken, does the person understand more clearly what to change, or only what kind of person we have judged them to be?

Before assigning responsibility, feedback must establish what happened, what requirement had been communicated, and who had access to the correct material. Contributions deserve thanks, and mistakes still need addressing. Not receiving a new version is not evidence of carelessness. A softer voice does not make blaming the wrong person correct.

## Thanks are not a prelude to assigning the next task

He Xiu had a car and had driven several teammates to and from their amateur team's activities on three consecutive Saturdays, saving them several changes of public transport. In the group chat, captain Ji Chuan praised him as the most selfless member of the team, then assigned him the driving every week of the following month. Ji Chuan saw this as showing trust in a reliable teammate.

He Xiu could cover only the additional week he had already agreed to. He had family plans in the following weeks and had never offered a regular driving service. If he refused now, however, it could look as though he had accepted the praise and then stopped caring about the team.

Ji Chuan eventually separated the two matters. He thanked He Xiu for the previous three trips and explained how they had helped the others. Then he asked about the new arrangements separately. He removed the unconfirmed assignments rather than require He Xiu to maintain an identity as "the most selfless." The team would need to arrange later transport another way. Until it was confirmed, the schedule could not say that a car was available.

Once praise carries an assumed obligation, the recipient is not simply receiving thanks. They are also being asked to prove that they deserve the compliment. Closeness and recognition matter to people, which can also make refusal harder. This is the book's interpretation of this arrangement; the gratitude-letter research is not used to establish it as a universal causal rule.

Thanks respond to help already given. Requests concern work not yet accepted. The former should remain valid even if the person later refuses the latter; a refusal should not revoke our earlier appreciation. Make appreciation specific where possible: whose needs they considered, or which step they handled thoughtfully. Do not rush to cast someone as endlessly selfless, endlessly reliable, or never entitled to rest.

People with decision-making authority need to pay particular attention to the weight their words carry. In paid work, thanks cannot replace appropriate compensation, resources, and task arrangements. Volunteer cooperation should not use honors to claim future labor in advance either. When a requirement needs to be stated, state it directly, and give people the opportunity to respond according to their circumstances. Praise is not a substitute for discussion.

## Let care show in everyday interactions

Gratitude, appreciation, and feedback may occur together, but they need not follow a “praise, criticism, praise” formula. If you only want to say thank you, let it end there. If something needs prompt correction, check the facts and be specific; do not invent strengths as a cushion.

Care is not limited to moments when someone contributes or makes a mistake. Remembering an important plan they mentioned, following through on a promise, or checking whether it is a convenient time before asking can also convey care. But ex-

pressing care does not automatically create an obligation to return it in equal measure. Nor must someone discuss private feelings publicly to prove their trust.

This chapter's guiding judgment can be simple: notice real contributions and express appreciation; when improvement is needed, explain the specific task and responsibility; seek fresh agreement for the next request. Recognition need not conceal a mistake, and a mistake need not conceal what someone has already done.

**Source notes** [1] R20, Kumar and Epley (2018), original abstract. The gratitude-letter experiment abstract was consulted; the restricted full text, detailed methods, and open data were not read. [2] R21, Kluger and DeNisi (1996), publicly accessible copy of the original paper. Reading covered the abstract and definitions, with limited sections of the theory and discussion. It did not include a complete close reading of all thirty-one pages or a study-by-study recheck. The attention mechanism is a preliminary theory, not evidence that this book's suggested wording has been tested and found effective. The three cases and the judgment that gratitude must not claim future labor are the book's own interpretations and value commitments. See the book's reference list for bibliographic details and reading scope.

Part IV

# Conversation and Cooperation

**Chapter 9**

# Why Sound Arguments Sometimes Go Unheard

*The manager, Chen, the company, and their conversations in this chapter are fictional.*

You may be saying, “There are advantages to doing it this way,” while the other person hears, “Your concerns are not worth discussing.” Adding another good reason may not move that conversation forward.

When people hear a demand, they judge not only the proposal but also their position in the situation. Does my experience count? If I mention a difficulty, will I be called uncooperative? Who will bear the consequences if the task cannot be done? When these questions go unanswered, a discussion about how to do the work can turn into a question of whether obedience is the only option.

So when a reasonable argument is not accepted, do not rush to conclude that the other person is unreasonable. **Separate the value of the proposal, the substance of the objection, and the person’s opportunity to explain it.** These are different matters. A more courteous phrase cannot resolve all three at once.

## After Chen lowered his head

At Monday's meeting, the manager announced that the warehouse would begin using a new inventory system the next day. He had compared several software packages and prepared arguments about reducing incorrect orders and making it easier for finance to reconcile records. To him, the direction was clear.

Chen frowned. "The old method has worked all this time. Why do we have to change now?"

Hearing "worked all this time," the manager assumed that he was being drawn into another argument over whether the new system had value. He raised his voice. "The company has to move forward. Everyone else can adapt. Why do you always have a problem?"

Chen lowered his head. "All right. We'll do as instructed."

The meeting ended there. Three days later, the new system still contained many blank entries. Looking at the screen, the manager felt that exactly what he had feared had happened: he had made himself perfectly clear at the meeting, but the instructions had not been carried out.

When he returned to the warehouse, he intended to ask Chen how many more times he needed to explain. At the doorway, however, he saw an employee using the old form to record the same batch of goods again. He stopped and asked, "Why does that still need filling in?"

The old form was still the handover record required by finance; discontinuing it needed separate approval. Chen explained that they had to enter data in the new system without stopping the old records. The day shift at least had a computer; the night shift had no usable computer at all. Training had covered the basic operations once, but no one had taken the night shift through the entire process.

“Why didn’t you say so at the meeting?” the manager asked.

“I asked one question, and suddenly I didn’t want progress,” Chen said. “How was I supposed to go on?”

The manager remembered his response to that question. He still believed the change should go ahead. But he could no longer attribute every blank entry to Chen’s unwillingness to listen.

“On Monday, I turned your question into an attitude problem,” he said. “We still have to deal with the missing entries. Walk me through it: what are you doing twice, and what can’t you do with the arrangements we have?”

They listed the problems one by one. The manager went to finance to clarify transitional records and coordinated equipment and training for the night shift. Chen compiled the missing items and information about the shifts, explaining which records had not yet been completed. He also acknowledged that he had failed to report those gaps promptly afterward. He could not simply wait for the manager to discover them in the system.

They neither abandoned the change nor completed every missing record that day. The manager remained responsible for completing the transition by the end of the month. But “every shift starts doing everything tomorrow” had to be rescheduled around the actual conditions.

## Why demands for obedience can make honest information harder to hear

The manager believed he was defending a sound proposal. Chen had begun defending something else: the right not to have all his experience and difficulties dismissed as backwardness. They were still talking about the system, but what each was trying to protect had changed.

This is an interpersonal shift worth noticing. Being willing to hear reasons does not mean being willing to lose the opportunity to give reasons. Especially when the cost of carrying out a decision falls on us, “Just do as you’re told” may make us more determined to hold on to the old approach. This is the book’s interpretation of the interaction. Psychological-reactance research also examines responses to threats to freedom, but one objection cannot diagnose Chen’s motives.[1]

A further difficulty is that the person holding decision-making power may mistake silence for understanding. Once Chen stopped arguing, the manager assumed that he had no remaining concerns. Yet silence might mean agreement, a belief that speaking is pointless, or reluctance to continue for the moment. To distinguish among them, we need specific information about arrangements and difficulties—not simply a quiet meeting room.

The manager had a reaction of his own that was easy to overlook. He had invested time in the proposal, so public opposition felt like a rejection of his judgment. The original question was how to record inventory accurately. Later, what he wanted to prove was that his instructions had to count. Once a work decision becomes a matter of defending status, thorough preparation may even make it harder to hear what was missed.

This does not mean that managers have no managerial responsibilities or that every requirement must be put to a fresh vote by everyone. It means that making a decision and blocking information are not the same exercise of authority. You can take responsibility for a direction while listening carefully to the conditions that might prevent it from being implemented.

## Distinguish not understanding, disagreeing, and being unable to comply

Someone who has not understood a proposal needs an explanation. Someone who understands but judges it differently needs a comparison of reasons. Someone who supports the direction but lacks equipment or time needs a change in arrangements. Repeating the same explanation will not have the same effect in all three cases.

In Chen's case, duplicate data entry and the night shift's equipment were verified working conditions. Praising his experience would not remove them. If he pointed out that the software failed to record a type of goods, the proposal itself would need checking. If the difficulty was knowing how to operate it, training would be needed. If the necessary conditions were clear and sup-

port genuinely available but an agreement still went unfulfilled, that specific responsibility would then need addressing. We should neither begin by looking only for an attitude problem nor end by blaming every error on the circumstances.

The description of the method in *Getting to Yes* encourages attention to interests behind positions. Here, that means going beyond "Switch tomorrow" and "Don't switch now" to ask what loss each party is trying to avoid. The manager wants accurate records. Chen is worried about leaving gaps while being unable to finish the work during his shift. These concerns can inform the arrangements; whether all can be met still requires an actual comparison.[2]

When reopening the conversation, make the question concrete: "From the moment this batch arrives until it has been recorded on both the old form and the new system, what steps are involved?" Asking someone to show you a process is more likely to yield facts you can address than asking them to defend "not wanting progress." This is the book's practical suggestion, not a line guaranteed to secure cooperation.

Also explain what new information can change. If equipment shortages can be coordinated but another department must decide about the old records, distinguish those areas of authority. Asking for views, only for the person to discover that nothing is open to discussion whatever they say, can easily turn the next request for input into another formality.

## Respect does not mean disguising a requirement as an invitation

The manager could say plainly: “Completing the change this month is a settled requirement. I am responsible for coordinating the transition. Let’s now check how shifts, training, and the old records will fit together. Report anything that genuinely cannot be done promptly. We cannot plan as though you already have conditions that are missing.”

This does not pretend that anyone can cancel the decision. Nor does it substitute “Feedback welcome” for responsibility for coordination. It explains what the employees can help shape and who must respond to the problems.

BayNVC links requests with allowing the other person to say no. Here, the method helps distinguish invitations from requirements. Where a choice genuinely exists, accept it. Where a work requirement has already been set, state it as a requirement and provide a channel for reporting difficulties. Do not ask whether someone is willing and then immediately accuse them when they say they are not.[3]

Where there is a clear danger or an urgent matter needing immediate attention, necessary measures can come first, followed by a review of reasons and responsibilities. There is no need to delay action to complete a conversational routine. Conversely, not every failure to prepare should be labeled an emergency that permits only execution and never the reporting of problems.

If raising difficulties publicly leads to retaliation, moving to a private or written channel may still be insufficient. Managers must make reporting genuinely workable. Those receiving demands must judge, in their own circumstances, whether to continue and whom to seek support from. Communication skills cannot replace these conditions of power.

## Do you want an agreement—or a way for the work to move forward?

When the manager left the warehouse the second time, he did not have a louder promise that everything would be completed. He had a plan identifying gaps, responsible people, and unresolved matters. It looked less impressive than an immediate nod, but showed him what to do next.

The next time someone does not accept your reasoning, ask what they have not understood, what they disagree with, or what they cannot currently do. Then consider whether you have also taken away the opportunity to raise questions.

For a sound argument to become part of cooperation, proving that you are right is not enough. It must leave room for the other person to explain how the work will actually unfold on their side.

**Source notes** [1] R01, Steindl et al. (2015), original abstract hosted by an author's institution. This is a research review; reading was limited to the abstract. The analysis of the manager and Chen is this book's interpretation. [2] P03, publisher's description of the method; the complete book was not read. [3] P02, the Requests section of BayNVC's practical guide; this is a practical proposal, not an effectiveness study. See the reference list for reading scope and bibliographic details.

**Chapter 10**

# How to Disagree and Continue Working Together

*The three stories in this chapter—including the people, conversations, times, and numbers—are fictional, not the author's or readers' real experiences.*

Sometimes people hear "There is a problem with your approach" as "There is something wrong with you." This is especially possible when we have invested a great deal in a plan, or are the person expected to make the decisions. When someone objects, what we first try to defend may no longer be the approach itself, but our competence, contribution, and authority to speak.

Expressing disagreement therefore involves more than dropping a conclusion in someone's lap. **Help them understand which choice you oppose, why you oppose it, and what you could do together next. They do not have to admit incompetence, and you do not have to withdraw your objection, before a conversation can continue.**

This does not mean that all disagreement comes from a wish to save face. Two people may genuinely need different things and bear different costs. Even after everything is clear, some matters will remain unacceptable. The following three stories examine these different possibilities.

## Do not send the other person straight into proving their usefulness

Lin Yao's family was preparing to move. The moving van was booked for the following Tuesday, and the keys to the old home had to be returned to the landlord on Wednesday. Her father, Lin Jianchuan, had made two trips to the new place, drawn the furniture layout on paper, and booked workers to dismantle and reassemble the furniture.

On Sunday, Lin Yao noticed that a set of cabinets drawn beside the window was 2.5 meters wide, while that wall was only 2.1 meters across. If they moved everything as planned, the cabinets would not fit, and they would have to pay for an additional round of dismantling and reassembly.

Holding the drawing, she said, "This plan of yours is completely unusable."

Her father did not continue discussing measurements. He put the drawing away and said that after all his work over the past few days, he was still not needed.

Lin Yao felt unfairly treated too. If the cabinets did not fit, they did not fit. Were they supposed to follow a mistaken plan just to make her father happy? The more she explained the dimensions, the more he emphasized the trips he had made. Both were telling the truth, but they were not responding to the same issue.

After dinner, Lin Yao spread out the drawing again without judging the whole plan. First she marked the positions that were confirmed to work, then circled the cabinets. The van and work-

ers would still come as booked; the other furniture would follow the original plan. What needed changing now was how to handle this set of cabinets.

Her father was still reluctant to give them up, but began measuring another wall in the new home with her. In the end, they could keep part of the set. What to do with the rest still needed a family discussion. They did not settle everything that day, but they could carry on packing without first deciding who was more useful to the family.

The point was not to start with praise and hide the criticism inside it. The van really was booked, most of the arrangements really did work, and the cabinets really did not fit. By separating those three facts, Lin Yao made it possible for her father to defend his contribution without also defending the mistaken placement.

Why can a plan turn into a judgment about the self? Some people tie their sense of deserving respect closely to a particular kind of performance: I must be capable, look after my family, or prove that I can still help. Caring about these things can motivate effort and make a challenge especially painful. Crocker and Knight's discussion of "contingencies of self-worth" concerns what people believe they must do to be worthy; those conditions can be both sources of motivation and points of vulnerability.[1]

From that perspective, her father might have heard not only "You got the measurements wrong" but also "You no longer know how to handle things." That is this book's interpretation of the story, not a psychological diagnosis of the father or a claim about all

older relatives. The same possibility would be worth considering with a young colleague who places great importance on professional competence.

Where a concern can be stated specifically, avoid dismissing everything at once. “This won’t fit here” and “Your arrangements are useless” leave very different openings for a response. The first allows people to measure the space together; the second can easily turn the conversation toward who is qualified to make decisions.

The person hearing an objection also has a responsibility. You may feel uncomfortable and still need to distinguish the specific problem being raised. Acknowledgment of your effort does not entitle you to demand acceptance of a mistake. Respecting someone does not mean preserving every decision they have made.

## Understanding a reason does not mean agreeing to a demand

A laundry usually closed at eight in the evening. Its owner, Chen Jing, wanted to change closing time to ten. Her employee, Pei Hang, disagreed.

Chen Jing had reasons for feeling urgency. Four customers had asked the previous week whether they could collect their clothes later after work, and a new shop had opened nearby. She felt that if the two of them were trying to make the business succeed, they could not reject every adjustment as soon as it was proposed.

Pei Hang was considering a different set of costs. His last direct bus home left at 8:30. Finishing at ten would require another way home. Moreover, the agreed working day ended at eight. Two additional hours had not been arranged simply because someone said, “Let’s all put in a bit more effort.”

At first, Chen Jing heard his objection as unwillingness to stand by the business, while Pei Hang saw the extension as the owner wanting more work out of him. If the conversation stopped there, both could find reasons to be angry.

Later, they described the proposed change more precisely. Did customers need late collection every day, or would an occasional late-opening day suffice? How much demand was there? Who would stay if the shop remained open, and how would their time and pay be arranged?

Chen Jing realized that although she had heard several inquiries, she did not yet know whether extending opening hours by two hours every day would be worthwhile. Pei Hang also learned that she had not already decided to withhold additional pay. She was worried about losing customers and had proposed the change before thinking through staffing.

They did not announce longer opening hours on the spot. Chen Jing would first spend a week recording the collection times customers actually requested, then calculate staffing and costs. Pei Hang continued working his original hours and also recorded inquiries about late collection. Whether to change opening hours would be discussed once those matters were clearer. Pei Hang had not committed to finishing at ten, and Chen Jing had not abandoned the effort to understand evening demand.

This disagreement differs from the moving story. Even if neither person felt offended, time and money still had to be arranged. Pei Hang's commute could not be dismissed as oversensitivity, and Chen Jing's concern for the business did not prove that profit was all she cared about.

We can often recall our own pressures immediately, while we need others to explain the costs they bear. Our own reasons have a full history in our minds; another person's objection may reach us as a bare "no." Pronin and colleagues' review discusses how people put greater trust in examining their own inner thoughts while more readily seeing bias in others' judgments. Knowing that we mean well does not prove that we have considered someone else's situation adequately.[2]

One practical step is to ask what the other person's reasons are and include them in the decision. Once Pei Hang explained the bus and his working hours, Chen Jing was no longer confronting a vague refusal to cooperate. She was considering a change in business hours that required arrangements for staffing, transport, and pay.

"Include" does not mean automatically satisfy. Understanding Chen Jing's fear of losing customers did not mean Pei Hang had agreed to overtime. Understanding his difficulty getting home did not mean the shop could never adjust its hours. Knowing the actual difficulties enables both sides to judge which conditions can change and which costs they are unwilling to bear.

## Make your objection something the other person can answer

In both stories, the useful changes were specific. Lin Yao stopped saying that the entire plan was useless and identified the cabinets that would not fit. Pei Hang did not have to prove that he was more reasonable than the owner. He needed to explain what he could not accept and why.

When expressing disagreement, begin by giving a full account: **what specifically I disagree with, what is already known, and what consequences concern me.** If key information is missing, identify it. If the facts are clear but priorities differ, discuss directly what each person is willing to bear.

For example, Pei Hang could replace “I’m not doing it” with “I can’t finish at ten under the current arrangements. We haven’t agreed on transport home or the additional working hours.” Chen Jing would then have concrete matters to respond to, rather than merely an attitude to judge.

This does not require the objector to supply a complete alternative plan. Pointing out that cabinets will not fit does not automatically make someone responsible for redesigning the whole home. Identifying gaps in overtime arrangements does not require an employee to solve the shop’s commercial pressures alone. But if we are willing to keep cooperating, we can specify what part we can take on rather than saying vaguely, “Whatever.”

The description of the method in *Getting to Yes* recommends looking beyond stated positions, understanding the interests that matter to each side, and searching for options together.[3] Here, “eight or ten” should not obscure more specific questions: when customers need the service, who can stay, and how additional work would be arranged. More precise questions help reveal whether a workable option exists.

Also, do not use “We only want what’s best for you” to end a discussion. Good intentions cannot give consent on someone else’s behalf. People still need a voice in the time, money, and responsibilities they are being asked to take on.

## Some things remain unacceptable even after the reasons are clear

Cheng Lu maintained donation records for a small mutual-aid project. An update for participants was due on Friday. At that point, 5,000 yuan had actually been received, and several supporters had promised to transfer another 3,000 yuan the following week.

The project leader wanted 8,000 yuan entered in the “received” column. He had no intention of taking the money. He feared that a smaller figure would undermine people’s confidence in continuing to support the project, and the additional 3,000 yuan had genuinely been promised.

Cheng Lu proposed listing the two amounts separately: 5,000 received, 3,000 pledged. This would acknowledge the supporters' promises without presenting money not yet received as already in hand.

The leader still insisted on recording all 8,000 as received. Cheng Lu ultimately handed over the records she had checked and explained that she would not take part in publishing a statement saying that all 8,000 yuan had arrived. If someone else needed to take over the task, she was willing to hand over the materials, but she would not verify that figure.

Better-sounding words did not produce agreement this time. Each understood the other's reasons and still made a different choice. One prioritized preserving confidence; the other believed that confidence should not be sustained through an inaccurate statement of receipts.

Expressing disagreement also helps clarify where cooperation is impossible. Continuing to work together cannot be placed above honesty and informed choice. Cheng Lu should not be required to agree just once to prove that she knows how to communicate.

In employment or other relationships of dependence, refusing can carry real costs. Arguing the matter out in public may not be appropriate. Someone may first check the records, choose a safer written channel, and specify what they have and have not verified. If seeking another person's help, they should consider whether that person can act independently. When threats or repeated humiliation occur, self-protection or ending a particular form of cooperation may matter more than another round of explanation.

Cooperation can continue not because both sides speak elegantly enough, but because facts are taken seriously, commitments are not imposed, and the person who disagrees still has a choice.

## Leave an answer that makes the next action clear

Disagreement need not become a rejection of a person, nor must it be swallowed to preserve a relationship.

Be specific about the objection, explain your grounds, and understand what the other person actually needs. If something can be checked together, agree on who will check it. If you can do only part, state the limit. If a commitment is unacceptable to you, decline it clearly.

The aim is to have a choice considered seriously, not to make another person concede defeat. After the discussion, the plan may change; only a small part of the cooperation may remain possible; or it may need to stop. Disagreement has practical substance when you know why you object and the other person knows what you will do next.

**Source notes** [1] R09, Crocker and Knight (2005), original abstract. Reading covered the abstract and bibliographic information for the authors' theoretical account, not the restricted full text. The discussion of role competence and family contribution is this book's application. [2] R22, Pronin, Gilovich, and Ross (2004), original abstract. This is a theoretical review; the full text and included studies were not read. It is not used to diagnose bias in the fictional characters. [3] P03, method points in the publisher's Book Description, not a close reading of the original book or empirical proof of the effectiveness of negotiation. The

three fictional stories illustrate the book's judgments; they do not establish that these approaches necessarily work. See the reference list for bibliographic details and reading scope.

**Chapter 11**

# How to Say No and Make Your Boundaries Clear

*Qiao Ning, Zhou Lan, and the work and family variations in this chapter are fictional. "Boundaries" is an everyday term for the limits of what someone takes on, not a personality diagnosis or a legal conclusion.*

Sometimes refusal is difficult not because the decision is hard to make, but because the moment of saying no feels so uncomfortable. You already know you cannot finish the work, yet still want to say "I'll try" to get past the immediate awkwardness.

This may preserve harmony for the moment while leading the other person to make a different plan. They think someone has taken on the task; you think you have not really agreed. As the deadline approaches, an unclear sentence becomes a source of hurt that both sides feel justified in holding.

This chapter's point is: **do not exchange a promise you cannot keep for the immediate relief of not having to refuse. First establish whether you have already agreed, then explain what you can take on now.** The other person may be disappointed. Existing responsibilities do not disappear because we call something a boundary.

## The message after “I’ll try”

At 4:30 on Friday afternoon, Zhou Lan sent a fifteen-page presentation. “The client needs to see it tomorrow. Could you redo the layout tonight? You’re quick at this.”

Qiao Ning still needed two hours to finish her own checking report and had to leave at 5:30. She had planned to work on her report first and finish the remainder according to her existing arrangements. Zhou Lan had helped her the previous month. Remembering that support, she hesitated to say immediately that she could not take this on.

“I’ll try,” she replied.

She had not actually freed up enough time for fifteen pages or recalculated her working hours. The sentence first accomplished something else: it spared her from confronting Zhou Lan’s disappointment on the spot.

At six, Zhou Lan asked, “Which page have you got to?”

Qiao Ning felt unfairly treated. She had not guaranteed that she would finish, so why was she already being asked for progress? But from Zhou Lan’s perspective, she had sent the file, received “I’ll try,” and heard nothing further about it being impossible. She had not looked for anyone else.

Qiao Ning began typing a long explanation of how busy she was, then stopped. If it ended with another “I’ll see what I can do,” Zhou Lan would still not know how to arrange the evening.

She rewrote her reply. “I didn’t make the scope clear earlier. I can’t take on these fifteen pages tonight, and I haven’t started editing them. You need to make another arrangement; please don’t plan on receiving the file from me tonight.”

Zhou Lan replied, “It doesn’t need to be that detailed. Just give it a quick tidy. It really won’t take long.”

Qiao Ning had already seen that the work involved more than changing fonts: charts and data also needed checking. She explained this without continuing to argue about whether she was busy enough. “This isn’t just layout. I still can’t take on the full revision tonight.”

After a pause, Zhou Lan said that her main concern was whether the client would understand three key charts. She would handle those pages first and leave the decorative changes for now. Qiao Ning did not therefore take on those three pages. She could understand the difficulty and still lack the time to do the work.

The exchange did not end with “No problem.” Zhou Lan genuinely needed to rearrange things and remained somewhat disappointed. Qiao Ning also had to acknowledge that her ambiguous response had delayed Zhou Lan’s search for another solution. She was not proving that she bore no responsibility. She was acting as quickly as possible to stop the misunderstanding from growing.

## Why it is hard to speak even when you know you cannot do it

The cost of agreeing often arrives later: several hours of work, or another task delayed. The cost of refusing is immediate: how the person will respond, whether you will seem cold, whether past favors will be brought up.

When immediate discomfort outweighs our assessment of future working time, we may soften our words as though avoiding “no” now allows the real choice to be postponed. That is this book’s interpretation of an ambiguous response like Qiao Ning’s. It does not mean that every indirect expression is evasive, or that the other person is certain to become angry.

The requester and the person being asked may also be calculating different costs. Flynn and Lake found that people asking for help underestimated the likelihood that others would agree to direct requests. One study pointed to requesters giving less consideration to the social costs of refusing and more to the practical costs of helping. This suggests that the two sides may be thinking differently; it cannot tell us whether a particular colleague will necessarily agree or refuse.[1]

The distinction matters. A requester may think, “Just tell me if it’s inconvenient,” while the other person worries about what their relationship will be like after a refusal. The requester cannot establish the absence of pressure simply by saying “It’s voluntary.” The recipient cannot use an imagined disappointment to accept work they cannot complete either.

If there have been threats or actual punishments, the concern is not merely overthinking. Power, support, and usable channels matter. We cannot expect the person in the weaker position to solve the situation just by speaking more bravely.

## First check whether you have already agreed

Declining a new request and being unable to fulfill an existing agreement involve different responsibilities.

Qiao Ning had said only “I’ll try,” so she needed to correct the expectation created by that ambiguity. If she discovered that she had clearly promised the day before to deliver fifteen pages that evening, she could not treat the work as a new request she had never accepted. She might still genuinely be unable to do it, but would need to explain the change and its impact early, identify what could be handed over, and consider remedies—not merely repeat “I have the right to refuse.”

Conversely, helping in the past does not make every new request automatically valid. Zhou Lan’s support the previous month deserved gratitude. Whether Qiao Ning could take on this task required a separate decision. Different expectations about mutual support can be discussed seriously; an unspoken obligation cannot simply be converted into an entire evening of someone’s time.

A boundary, then, is not a phrase that makes us permanently right. It must be considered in light of what has already been said, shared obligations, and actual capacity. If you consistently

leave common tasks to others and preserve only your own convenience, the objection may be precisely that the burden is unfairly shared.

## Decide the scope before choosing the words

Before searching for a sentence that will hurt no one, answer a practical question: will I take this on, and how much of it will I take on?

If you cannot do the whole task, say that first. Do not ask a series of detailed questions and only then disclose that you never intended to undertake it. The other person may interpret the ongoing discussion as a handover already in progress.

If you genuinely want to spend ten minutes offering reading comments, specify the limit: “I can only identify the points that most interfere with understanding. I won’t be revising charts, checking data, or delivering an edited file.” Those ten minutes must also be genuinely available. A refusal does not need an additional gift of labor to qualify as polite.

BayNVC describes a request as a specific invitation that permits a no. It provides a practical comparison here: both sides need to know what is being requested, what has been accepted, and what remains unagreed. It does not require a fixed wording that guarantees the other person’s happiness.[2]

Nor must you lay out all your private arrangements for comparison. You can say that you have no time available to take on the task that evening without proving that what you will do after leaving is more important than the other person's client. Making the outcome clear is different from making every reason public.

New information is still worth hearing. A deadline genuinely moving, a full revision becoming one question you can answer, or confirmation that the task is already an assigned duty could change the judgment. But repeating "It really won't take long" does not estimate your working hours for you. More urging does not mean less work.

## When the other person has authority to assign your work

If Zhou Lan were replaced by a supervisor with authority to reassign tasks, refusal could not be considered only as a response to a private request. The conflict between tasks would need to be made visible to someone able to decide.

Suppose the checking report and presentation revision were both due that day, each needed another two hours, and only one working hour remained. Qiao Ning could say, "These deadlines cannot both be met. Please confirm which comes first and who will take over the other task, or when its deadline should move." These times are new, explicit conditions for this variation, not a schedule already established in the original story.

This reports capacity and consequences while asking for priorities. If the supervisor chooses the presentation first, the report's delay must become known at the same time. A change of priorities cannot be required while all previous deadlines are still silently assumed to stand.

Repeated overload also calls for changes in resources and the division of work. Records of tasks, deadlines, and reported difficulties can be kept, and a genuinely usable coordination channel chosen. A third party controlled by the same supervisor may not provide independent support. Where there is no safe space to refuse, assess risks and support first; you do not have to prove yourself in a single public argument.

This chapter provides no jurisdiction-specific, contractual, or institutional information and does not determine readers' employment rights. The distinction it preserves is that communication can clarify a conflict, but a sentence cannot create extra time or change a power structure.

## After a refusal, the relationship may still need adjusting

Indirectness is not inherently wrong. The question is whether both people understand the same outcome. If "I'm rather busy this week" merely leaves someone waiting, you can add, "I can't take this on this week. Please make your arrangements without me." You do not need an aggressive tone to be clear.

The other person may reasonably remain disappointed after understanding. Support they expected is no longer available, and they must rearrange things. You may also lose some convenience or closeness. No perfect sentence eliminates every trade-off.

Disappointment is not the same as a threat, however. You can hear disappointment while keeping your decision. Humiliation, actual retaliation, or being prevented from leaving calls for a different communication approach, support, or an end to the interaction. It should not be treated as another exercise in wording.

When Qiao Ning finally put down her phone, she did not feel as though nothing had happened. She knew Zhou Lan still faced a difficulty and that she should have been clear earlier. But at least Zhou Lan was no longer waiting for a file no one was working on.

How do we refuse and explain our boundaries? First establish the responsibilities already accepted, then make clear what we can take on now. We can care about someone's difficulties and withstand an instance of disappointment. Do not make the present easier by leaving a promise you already know you cannot deliver.

**Source notes** [1] R23, Flynn and Lake (2008), original abstract, reporting experimental and naturalistic studies. The full text, individual methods, and original data were not read. The analysis of immediate awkwardness and future workload is this book's interpretation. [2] P02, BayNVC's Requests explanation, a practical definition that does not determine job responsibilities or the fairness of a refusal. Honesty, autonomy, shared responsibility, and responding to risk are this book's value commitments. See the reference list for bibliographic details and reading scope.

**Chapter 12**

# How to Influence Others and Examine What Influences You

*The course, people, dates, prices, and available places in this chapter are fictional. They do not refer to a real product and involve no actual purchase or registration.*

When making decisions, we often respond to more than reasons. If someone helps us first, refusing becomes harder. If others have participated, we hesitate a little less. As a deadline approaches, something we have not thought through suddenly seems to demand a decision.

These responses have everyday uses. We cannot investigate everything from scratch; experience, recommendations, and other people's behavior can help us find a direction. The problem is that **cues that help us choose can quietly start choosing for us.** We think we are judging whether something is worthwhile, when we may simply be trying to escape a sense of indebtedness, fear of missing out, or feeling out of step with everyone else.

Influencing others should therefore be about more than getting a yes. And being influenced does not mean we must automatically choose the opposite. The question is: am I agreeing because this has become a better fit for me, or because refusing has become harder?

## Zhou Yu had already picked up the pen

Zhou Yu attended an introductory paper-craft session. At the end, the organizer gave each participant a materials pack, introduced a longer course, and showed photographs of previous students together.

“You did very well just now. You’re suited to taking this further. There are two places you can still apply for. Why not fill out an expression-of-interest form?” she said.

Zhou Yu had intended only to try the activity. With the materials pack already in his hand and a pen being offered, simply saying he was leaving felt uncomfortable. Filling out one form probably would not matter, he thought.

The form described three sessions: November 6, 13, and 20, each from 7 to 9 p.m. The full course cost 120 yuan, including materials. He wanted to attend all three, but would not know his work schedule for November 13 until noon the next day.

It was five in the afternoon on November 2. Zhou Yu asked whether the form had to be filled in immediately.

“Haven’t you wanted to learn this all along? If you keep hesitating, you’ll regret it later,” the organizer said. She was concerned that the purchasing date was approaching and wanted to confirm numbers quickly.

Zhou Yu put the pen back on the table. He did not accuse the course of being a scam. He asked several further questions: when did expressions of interest close, did earlier forms receive priority, was the materials pack conditional on signing up, and could a missed session be made up?

The specific arrangements were these: expressions of interest closed at 6 p.m. on November 3 and would then be processed together. Filling in the form earlier gave no priority and did not guarantee a place. Materials purchases would be confirmed on November 4. There were no single-session places or make-up sessions for this course. The materials pack was an unconditional gift and could be taken home whether or not the recipient enrolled. The form itself was not a commitment to pay.

These answers changed his plan. He could check his work schedule at noon the next day and still meet the deadline. He did not need to fill in the form merely to seem cooperative now. But if his schedule did not fit, he might still miss this course. Clarifying the conditions did not preserve every possible opportunity.

The organizer later restated the arrangements without using the materials pack or “Haven’t you wanted to learn?” to hurry him. Zhou Yu remained grateful for the introductory session. What he agreed to was making a decision the next day, not enrolling in the longer course.

## Why a small kindness can make a request feel heavier

Wanting to reciprocate after receiving help is one reason many relationships continue. Someone makes things easier for you, and you are willing to help when they need it. This need not mean that every kindness conceals a calculation.

The difficulty is that the feeling of owing a return may arrive before we have assessed the new request. Before Zhou Yu had checked his availability for the three sessions, he was already wondering whether not filling in the form would let down the person who gave him the materials. The course timing had not become more suitable; the feeling of refusal had changed.

An early experiment by Regan found that receiving a small favor from someone affected subsequent compliance with that person's request. The author offered reciprocity pressure as one explanation and discussed limitations, including why the experiment did not establish that liking had no effect. This does not mean that all gifts are manipulation or determine the motives of real people who give them.[1]

The check proposed by this book is whether I am still judging separately my willingness to thank someone for one thing and my willingness to agree to the next. If enrollment was not a condition of the gift when it was given, the gift should not later become a debt the recipient never knew about. That is this book's position on honesty and autonomy, not a moral rule that one experiment can directly establish.

The person seeking to influence someone must face the same check. You can help a colleague and later make a request. But if their refusal makes you immediately withdraw your earlier goodwill or say “So that’s the kind of person you are,” recognize that you are turning the help into an undisclosed condition.

## Cues can be useful—but what do they actually establish?

Cialdini’s official description of his approach identifies reciprocity, scarcity, authority, social proof, and other influence cues. This chapter uses that classification to help identify what we are responding to. It does not adopt the webpage’s claims of universality or effect sizes, or treat it as a close reading of the original research behind each principle.[2]

A teacher’s experience can make a course worth investigating. Whether that experience relates to what you want to learn still requires examining the actual course. A group photograph shows that people were present; it does not by itself show that everyone completed the course, was satisfied, or shared your goals.

Genuine scarcity is useful information too. Two places mean that not everyone can attend, but do not automatically change your work schedule for November 13. The deadline determines how long you can wait, not how suitable the course is. You may perfectly reasonably choose to join after checking. Accepting that you will miss it after checking does not mean you lack judgment.

Preserving these distinctions does not require suspecting everyone each time. What matters is asking a cue to carry only the information it actually supplies. Do not substitute reputation for content, photographs for suitability, or an approaching deadline for your own availability.

We may also find reasons to justify actions we have already begun. Once Zhou Yu picked up the pen, putting it down could feel like going back on his word. But preparing to fill in a form and deciding to enroll are different stages. If you have not thought it through, allow yourself to stop. You do not have to extend a commitment further and further merely to stay consistent with an earlier movement. This is the book's everyday application of consistency cues, not a measured account of Zhou Yu's mental processes.

## How can we influence someone without deciding for them?

From the organizer's side, the issue is more than avoiding manipulative wording. She genuinely needs suitable participants and needs to know numbers before purchasing materials. She can explain the course's value seriously while setting out its real limits.

For example: "These are three basic paper-craft sessions. You'll complete one simple item in each session; the course does not provide a professional certificate. Here are the times and cost. Expressions of interest close at six tomorrow evening, and places will be confirmed together afterward. Applying earlier does not give priority. The materials pack is a gift from the introductory session; you can take it even if you don't join."

If Zhou Yu wants vocational training, this information may lead him not to enroll. If he wants to make a simple craft once a week, it may give him better reasons to join. **Helping unsuitable participants recognize the mismatch and helping suitable participants decide are both part of honest influence.**

She can also ask what he most needs to confirm, rather than treat every hesitation as an objection to overcome. If the missing information is his work schedule, more student photographs will not supply it. If the real deadline comes before his schedule is confirmed, say plainly that waiting may cost him a place and let him decide whether he can accept that—not promise that he will lose nothing.

BayNVC connects a request with the possibility of hearing no, providing a practical comparison for invitations.[3] But "You can refuse" must be supported by what happens afterward. Refusal cannot be followed by humiliation, probing into private details, or an invented new countdown. Preserving choice does not mean that the organizer has no deadlines or conditions. They should be stated beforehand.

The standard of success changes accordingly. Securing an immediate yes from someone known to be unable to attend may improve enrollment figures without creating the cooperation the course needs. There is no guarantee that honesty produces a higher enrollment rate. This book chooses to make commitments as informed, genuine, and workable as possible.

## Fluent AI advice is another influence worth checking

When AI presents advice in an orderly way and a considerate tone, it can become easy to ask fewer questions. We still need to check whether it knows our actual constraints, whether it has presented assumptions as facts, and what its cited material really supports.

If it keeps listing the benefits of attending simply because you want to join, your work schedule does not become any more certain. If it merely translates your hesitation into “not being brave enough,” check whether it is choosing your goal for you. These are this book’s expectations for evaluating tools, not reports of a platform’s effectiveness or the frequency of such behavior.

When talking with AI, you can also reject a goal it proposes, disagree with its feedback, or end the conversation. A system that keeps encouraging you does not thereby gain authority to make commitments for you, access private information, or act on your behalf.

## Put down the pen and decide again

Recognizing influence cues did not make Zhou Yu refuse every invitation. It simply returned the course to the questions it should have faced in the first place: what would he learn, when would he attend, what would he give, and which conditions remained unknown?

The next time you want someone to accept a suggestion, reverse the perspective. Are you offering information that helps them judge, or pressure that merely makes refusal more frightening? Can you explain genuine advantages and limitations together? Will their disagreement still be respected?

Influence is an everyday ability and a responsibility that requires self-examination. Ask not only “How do I get them to agree?” but also “Do they know what they are agreeing to?”

**Source notes** [1] R24, Regan (1971), publicly accessible PDF of the original paper. Reading covered the abstract, design and sample, relevant textual results, and discussion of limitations. It did not include a complete recheck of all thirteen pages, original data, or modern replication evidence. The hosting website is not the author’s institution. [2] P07, the author’s official introduction to the principles. This classification is not a unified law of human nature validated by this book. [3] P02, BayNVC’s Requests explanation. The story and standards for invitations are this book’s synthesis, fiction, and value commitments. See the reference list for bibliographic details and reading scope.

Part V

# Facing Conflict and Repairing Relationships

**Chapter 13**

# How to Reassess a Situation When Goodwill Is Not Enough

*The characters, exhibition, and delivery process below are original fictional examples.*

Someone can sincerely want to help you and still make a mess of the job. Reassessing trust begins with identifying where they went wrong, rather than choosing between “They’re a good person” and “They’re completely untrustworthy.”

That is difficult because trust is often intertwined with affection. We have seen someone’s willingness to help and remember how they stayed when things were hard. We hesitate to ask whether they can finish on time, as if the question would deny all their previous kindness. After disappointment, we may reverse the same emotional reasoning: since they let us down this time, perhaps their earlier kindness was false too.

The problem is that we are substituting our overall feelings about a person for a judgment about the task in front of us. To stop swinging between these extremes, we need to distinguish goodwill, actual capability, and the commitments made.

## The third “Don’t worry”

Ming Yue was preparing an exhibition of neighborhood oral histories. Her friend He Chuan was helping turn interview recordings into text. The first time, he delivered two days late, saying he had underestimated the length of the recordings. The second time, he delivered on time but left out several sections. Ming Yue rushed to fill the gaps without seriously discussing how to avoid a repeat.

He Chuan did more than offer reassuring words. When an event was short of help, he came to move tables. When older participants could not find the interview venue, he met them at the junction. Remembering this, Ming Yue gave him the third batch of material as well. She specifically reminded him that the text had to go for layout, leaving little time to make up for delays. He Chuan said, “Don’t worry. I’ll get it done.”

By five in the evening on November 3, only that night and the following morning remained before the noon deadline. There were six recordings, each ten minutes long. He Chuan had delivered only two. Ming Yue opened the files and confirmed that the two were usable, but her heart sank: four were still outstanding, and the person doing the layout was waiting.

“How many times have I explained this?” she said. “Does asking nicely make any difference at all?”

He Chuan grew anxious too. “It’s not that I don’t want to help. I’ll push on tonight.”

Ming Yue was about to continue criticizing him, then stopped and asked how long he could actually work that evening. He admitted that he had only the hour from five to six. After that, he had no free time before the deadline. He had known his schedule was tight when he agreed but had assumed he could somehow squeeze the work in, and had kept putting off saying so.

They had previously done a trial: preparing and checking the text from ten minutes of equally difficult audio took one hour. Saying "I'll push a little harder" would not remove the working hours needed for the four remaining recordings.

Ming Yue contacted a backup helper who knew the template and had also completed a trial to the same standard. This person could work only from nine to noon the next day: three hours. The four sections could be delivered independently, and the source files were ready to hand over immediately. She therefore left one recording with He Chuan and passed the other three to the backup helper. She also told the layout colleague that this schedule had no allowance for checking and rework, so delivery was still at risk of delay.

Watching the files being reassigned, He Chuan asked, "Does this mean you'll never ask me to help with anything again?"

Ming Yue did not immediately pronounce on their entire future. She first confirmed that the files had been sent, then said, "We have to arrange this according to what's left and what you can actually do. We can still be friends. But I can't give you the next batch of recordings close to a deadline on the same terms."

## Why kindness cannot guarantee capability

He Chuan's willingness to help answered the question, "Does he care about this project and this friend?" Whether he could finish the recordings depended on other conditions: whether he knew how to do the work, how fast he worked, what else he had to do, and how much time he could set aside.

Ming Yue had seen the first part and supplied a positive answer to the second. There was an emotional reason for this shortcut: asking a friend for progress felt like scrutinizing him; accepting reassurance felt like protecting the relationship. But the cost of not asking did not disappear. It was postponed until delivery, when she and those waiting for the files bore it together.

Mayer, Davis, and Schoorman's model of organizational trust distinguishes ability, benevolence toward the other party, and adherence to principles. It treats ability as specific to a domain: reliability in one kind of task does not establish competence in another. This is a distinction offered by a theoretical model, not a scale for scoring friends. [1]

In the story, He Chuan's willingness to move tables and meet people does not contradict his inability to finish the recordings on time. His kindness need not be declared false, nor should it cause the delivery problem to be overlooked. Ming Yue needs to change the specific way she relies on him, not first pass judgment on his entire character.

He Chuan cannot answer simply, “I meant well,” either. Having agreed, he had a responsibility to report a shortage of available time as soon as possible. An inaccurate estimate of capacity explains part of the failure. Not reporting promptly is a separate failure for which he still needs to take responsibility.

## Why explaining the importance again still does not help

Ming Yue repeatedly said the exhibition was important. He Chuan repeatedly said he understood. If what was missing was four hours of work, another explanation of its importance could not produce those four hours.

This is one reason well-intentioned communication can disappoint us: we treat “They understand me” as “They now have the means to finish.” When someone expresses understanding but results still fail to appear, we may be left with only one explanation: they do not really care.

Sometimes that is true. But the problem could also be insufficient skill, too many tasks, or agreeing too quickly. Distinguishing these possibilities requires questions about the actual work, not just a stronger promise.

“Which sections are finished? How much remains? How many hours are available before the deadline?” These questions address the immediate risk. Only when He Chuan said he had one hour did Ming Yue know that waiting for him to finish the whole

batch was no longer viable. She did not need to establish every private detail of his schedule before being entitled to reassign the files.

If progress is unconfirmed, first examine what can be handed over. If the work has never been tried, complete a small sample before estimating the scope. Checking serves planning; it need not turn every offer of help from a friend into an interrogation. The more critical the task and the harder a delay is to remedy, the less we can let embarrassment about asking substitute for judgment.

## After disappointment, conclusions still have a scope

“These deadline-bound transcription tasks have not met the agreement several times” can be checked against records. “He’s insincere with everyone” has no such basis in this story.

Making the conclusion accurate does not reduce He Chuan’s responsibility. Precisely because the problem is clear, Ming Yue can make a specific change: stop giving him complete batches close to a deadline. If she wishes to work with him again, she can arrange an early trial, use staged handovers, or accept only the on-site help he handles better.

She can also reduce contact. Repeated missed commitments and undisclosed delays may have imposed more than she is willing to bear. She does not need to suffer another loss to prove that she has given enough chances.

The reverse is worth noticing too. To prove that we will not be fooled again, we may refuse to acknowledge even work that is genuinely done well later. If we are willing to reconsider, we can look at conduct relevant to the original problem: timely reporting, or completing a smaller task as agreed, rather than merely how appealing an apology sounds. Whether to offer that opportunity remains the decision of the person bearing the risk.

## Gratitude for past help does not promise future trust

He Chuan worried about being replaced. Ming Yue worried about hurting him. Both feelings were real, but the remaining material still needed handing over. Requiring Ming Yue to leave all four recordings with him would turn emotional reassurance into a new work risk.

She could say, “Thank you for the two sections you’ve finished. I’ll use them. The rest need to be reassigned now.” That neither cancels the gratitude nor promises to restore the original arrangement.

The same applies to the time already spent completing his work. Ming Yue might think that, having covered for him twice, she should persist once more so the previous effort would not be wasted. But past effort cannot be recovered. What matters now is comparing the consequences of continuing to wait with those of handing over the work immediately. This is the book’s analysis of the choice, not a demand that she dismiss the value of her earlier effort.

If the other person prevents files from being retrieved, makes threats, or persistently harasses her, the priority is no longer finding a gentler way to express thanks. It is retaining the material, reducing further exposure, and finding suitable support. A relationship cannot justify withholding work or forcing cooperation to continue.

After the handover, Ming Yue still faced a schedule with no spare time. Changing the person doing the work did not automatically secure the exhibition. It did, however, let everyone plan according to actual progress instead of continuing to wait around a reassuring “Don’t worry.”

When goodwill is not enough, what is worth retaining is neither blind trust nor suspicion of everyone. It is a more precise statement: I can recognize what you have done and use that evidence to decide how far I am willing to rely on you for the next task.

**Source note** [1] R13, Mayer, Davis, and Schoorman (1995), original paper. Consultation of a university-hosted copy covered relevant passages on definitions, ability and benevolence, distinctions among factors, context, and limitations on printed pages 712, 717–721, and 726–729. The full 26 pages were not closely read, and subsequent empirical research was not checked. The model’s propositions and this book’s extensions to friendship and delivery are distinguished in the references and this chapter’s discussion.

The dates, quantities, trial working speeds, and characters’ reactions in the text are fictional conditions, not research data.

**Chapter 14**

# How to Acknowledge Mistakes and Gradually Rebuild Trust

*The characters and the publication, printing, and borrowing incidents below are original fiction, not the experiences of the author or readers, or cases from research.*

An apology is especially likely to go off course when we are so eager to prove we are not a bad person that we fail to explain what we actually did wrong.

We want others to continue respecting us, and we want to believe we deserve that respect. Admitting that we have hurt someone we work with can threaten that wish. A discussion that should concern their loss becomes an account of our own hard work and good intentions. The less they accept it, the more we explain. In the end, the affected person is expected to comfort the one who came to apologize.

Repair requires a different focus: **first make clear what you decided and what it affected, then take corrective action that can be checked. How far you can be trusted afterward depends gradually on actual conduct and the other person's choices. One apology cannot secure that trust in advance.**

## Acknowledge the act without condemning your whole self

Jiang Nan was doing publicity for a creative workshop. She photographed Shu Yan's unfinished sketches and put them in a public album without asking. Outsiders commented on the sketches as if they were finished work. When Shu Yan approached her, Jiang Nan's first thought was: after all the effort she had put in, how could anyone think she would deliberately harm a colleague?

She wrote a long explanation: the event needed material, she had been rushing to meet the schedule, and she had only meant to help. Only at the end did she add, "I'm sorry if this made you uncomfortable." What Shu Yan still faced, however, was an unanswered question: why should someone else decide when her work would be shown?

Before sending the message, Jiang Nan reread it and removed the part asking Shu Yan to sympathize with her. She acknowledged that publishing without asking had been her decision and had taken away Shu Yan's opportunity to choose when to show the work. She first removed the photographs she controlled and contacted the two people she knew had reposted them. One confirmed removal; the other did not reply. She reported those two outcomes accurately rather than claiming everything was resolved. Because a new public correction would mention Shu Yan again, she drafted it and waited for Shu Yan's approval.

Shu Yan was willing to read the correction but still asked that sketches not be posted directly in future. They did not immediately reconcile. The conversation had at last moved, though, from "Why do you think so badly of me?" back to "How did this image become public, and what can be done now?"

Jiang Nan's earlier difficulty speaking did not come from uncertainty about whether the photograph had been posted. She had heard acknowledging this mistake as admitting that she had always been disrespectful. When a single error is bound too tightly to our worth as a whole person, we can become busy defending ourselves and overlook the responsibility already within our power to take.

In her research on apologies, Schumann proposes that hurting others can threaten a person's view of themselves as good, prompting avoidance of acknowledgment and a turn toward defensiveness. Her writing experiments offer limited support: in one experiment, people who first reflected on values important to them wrote more complete apologies and offered fewer defensive responses. [1] The point here is not to give yourself a pep talk before asking for forgiveness. It is to see that admitting a particular mistake does not require first rejecting your entire self.

Do not turn "I published your sketches without asking" into "I've always been a bad person." Nor should "I'm not a bad person" become "So I need not take responsibility this time." Earlier contributions can remain recognized, and responsibility for this act must remain too.

## Do not leave the affected person to design the entire remedy

Gu Hang, who worked at a print shop, took an order for posters advertising a Sunday event. The version approved by the customer said two in the afternoon. He sent an older version to the printer, still showing ten in the morning. The customer discovered the error after delivery on Friday. Two partner businesses had already received posters, and the digital version was on a page Gu Hang managed.

At first, Gu Hang wanted to say that another reminder from the customer would have prevented the problem. Reviewing the records, he saw that the customer had already approved the correct version. He had failed to check the copy he sent. He stopped asking the customer to answer for that omission.

Rather than simply saying, “Tell me what compensation you want,” he began with actions he already knew were needed: withdrawing the incorrect digital version, telling both partners not to display the posters, and checking with the printer whether replacements could be completed by noon on Saturday. He separately told the customer the feasible timetable, his proposal to pay the reprinting costs, and which location had not yet confirmed retrieval of the wrong posters. How to word the public correction, and whether the original publicity schedule was still workable, remained for the customer to decide according to actual needs.

The customer was still anxious and did not say it was all right merely because he apologized sincerely. Nor could Gu Hang report an unanswered message as confirmed retrieval. But the customer did not have to teach him from the beginning which page he controlled or where he had sent posters.

After a mistake, we may rush to end the embarrassment. “Tell me what to do” seems to hand over decision-making power, but it may also shift the labor of checking, contacting people, and comparing options onto the other person. Taking responsibility means beginning with matters within your control, while leaving choices that require the other person’s decision to them.

An explanation of the cause should help clarify the situation too. Gu Hang could say that he sent an old copy and omitted the check before the posters left the printer. “I’ve been terribly busy” could not replace those two steps. If an explanation merely seeks less blame, it will not make the mistake easier to correct. If it identifies where judgment or action went wrong, it may help change the next set of arrangements.

Keep checking what is unknown, and act on what is established. One unrecovered poster is no reason to leave up a digital version you can remove. Nor should proving sincerity involve publishing the customer’s private messages for everyone to see.

## Making good a loss does not restore your previous permissions

Du Cheng borrowed his friend Xu Heng's camera for a trip. He failed to put away the rain cover as they had agreed, and water got into the equipment. He acknowledged the lapse, agreed on repair arrangements with Xu Heng, paid the costs, and gave him the repair shop's inspection results.

After the equipment came back, Du Cheng wanted to borrow it for another trip. Xu Heng said the repair had been dealt with, but he was not willing to lend it again for now. Du Cheng struggled to accept this. He had not refused to pay, and he had apologized. Why was Xu Heng still unwilling to give him a chance?

He was treating two things as a single exchange: I put things right, so you restore your original trust. But agreeing on repairs was not agreeing to bear the risk of another loan. Du Cheng could decide how he would look after equipment. He could not decide when Xu Heng would be willing to lend it again.

Lewicki and colleagues' scenario-based research indicates that people evaluate apologies differently depending on their components and the nature of the breach of trust. [2] How an apology is expressed deserves care. But evaluating an apology and entrusting someone with another important matter remain different questions. The research also does not establish that including a specified set of elements should restore every permission within a real relationship.

If future cooperation is desired, changes need to concern the relevant conduct: how the scope of use will be agreed, who will check it, and how problems will be reported promptly. The other person may gradually have fewer concerns or may keep their distance. Neither response should be rewritten as a failure to recognize your sincerity.

Those with decision-making power especially need to avoid turning an apology into another demand. After acknowledging a mistake, a person in charge should not require the affected person to express forgiveness publicly as a condition of continued participation. Choosing a communication channel, retaining necessary records, and seeking suitable support may matter more than another face-to-face explanation.

## Where repair begins

A person receiving an apology need not choose between “I trust everything” and “None of it counts.” They can acknowledge the remedy already completed while identifying what remains unresolved and the extent of contact they currently want.

The person apologizing need not rely on immediate reassurance from the other person to decide whether their actions have value. Stop what needs stopping, accurately describe what needs checking, and continue carrying the responsibilities that are yours.

Acknowledging a mistake does not mean proving yourself worthless. Repairing trust does not mean proving the other person has finally stopped being angry. Face the specific conduct first, change the actual arrangements, and accept that the relationship remains for both people to decide.

**Source notes** [1] R25, Schumann's (2014) paper hosted by the author's laboratory. Consultation covered the abstract, theoretical passages on self-protection, Experiment 1's results, and relevant results and limitations from Experiment 2. This remains a limited reading of the original text, not a close reading of all eight pages or a recalculation of the statistics. The overall difference in defensiveness in Experiment 2 did not reach conventional statistical significance, and psychological mediation remains to be tested. Experiment 1 is not generalized into a stable effect across all situations. [2] R14, original abstract of Lewicki and colleagues (2016). Consultation remains limited to the abstract and bibliographic information. The research concerns evaluations of scenarios, not evidence for this book's procedure or long-term repair in real relationships. The three stories are this book's original fictional explorations; the remedies are not legal conclusions, judgments about equipment reliability, or psychotherapy findings. See References and Scope of Consultation.

For forgiveness and future contact, see the next chapter.

**Chapter 15**

# Understanding Forgiveness, Responsibility, and the Future of a Relationship

*The stories below about authorship credit, family contact, and a shared home are original fiction. They do not describe the experiences of the author or readers, or actual research participants.*

"I'm not going to argue about this anymore" does not mean "I'm willing to work with you again." Receiving an apology, feeling calmer, becoming close again, and cooperating once more are different things. They need not happen together.

After harm, people must deal with what has happened while also considering whether their wishes will be disregarded again. The person asking forgiveness may be eager to restore the old relationship. Bystanders may want to end the awkwardness. The affected person may still be weighing the risk they would bear next time. Everyone says "Move forward," but they may not mean the same future.

This chapter's answer is: **the past that needs acknowledging must not be erased, and responsibilities that need addressing remain. The people involved must choose their future contact in light of real conditions. The word "forgiveness" cannot decide everything at once.**

## Correcting the credit does not require writing together again

Zhou Ru and Ning Zhou had written a short community play together. At the public performance, Ning Zhou claimed to have done the main creative work himself, and the program did not name Zhou Ru. When she objected, he told her not to make an issue of it. Three years later, Ning Zhou acknowledged deliberately omitting the joint credit, corrected the event record, and apologized. He hoped to invite her to write the next play.

Zhou Ru read the correction. It mattered to her: she no longer had to keep proving that she had done more than merely lend a hand. She did not want to keep arguing over the old program, but she did not agree to the new project. She did not want to place another work under their joint decision-making.

Ning Zhou was disappointed. He felt that if she was willing to accept the apology, they should be able to start again. Zhou Ru explained that recognizing the correction of an old wrong and agreeing to write together next time were not the same decision. She asked him not to put her name into the new plan beforehand.

This was not necessarily a failure by either person to understand “forgiveness.” Ning Zhou wanted to restore collaboration; Zhou Ru wanted to stop having to prove her contribution repeatedly. Those were different wishes. Asking only “Have you forgiven me or not?” could hide all these specific differences.

Philosophical discussion offers more than one definition of forgiveness too. Russell and Warmke’s account distinguishes forgiveness from excusing, forgetting, and restoring a relationship.

A relatively common view allows forgiveness without reconciliation, while other authors disagree. [1] This reminds us that in ordinary conversation it helps to clarify whether we are discussing our attitude to the past or new arrangements for contact and work.

This book takes a clear position: new cooperation still requires the person's agreement. Respecting someone's capacity to change does not mean requiring the previously affected person to bear the risk of testing that change. Declining a new project does not require remaining angry to justify the decision.

## Those urging reconciliation should examine what they want to avoid

After Shen Yi changed careers, her maternal uncle repeatedly joked about her income and choices at family gatherings. She had said she did not like it, but the subject continued to be used to liven up the room. Later, her uncle acknowledged that those remarks were inappropriate and promised to stop making her the joke.

Before the next family meal, her older cousin urged her to come. An elder had already backed down, the cousin said; staying away would put everyone in a difficult position. Shen Yi had not asked the family to cut off contact with her uncle. She was willing to arrange a separate meeting with her cousin, but would not attend this gathering.

Her cousin wanted the table to be lively again and did not want the job of explaining who was absent and why. Those wishes were understandable. But the cousin faced an uncomfortable gathering; Shen Yi faced the prospect of sitting there again while someone crossed a limit she had clearly stated. The cost of having one person attend to solve everyone's awkwardness was not shared equally.

Her cousin eventually stopped asking Shen Yi to prove her generosity. She explained the absence in the way Shen Yi was comfortable with and arranged another time for the two of them to meet. Whether Shen Yi would return to family gatherings in future was not settled that day.

Such pressure need not come from malice. Bystanders may see an immediate awkward silence without bearing the apprehension involved in renewed closeness. "Don't make everyone uncomfortable" can then become their most urgent concern. This is the book's interpretation of the situation, not a judgment that everyone urging reconciliation is selfish. The question to examine is whether our suggestion is again asking the same person to carry more.

If we genuinely want to help, we can handle our own part: arrange different times, accept someone's absence, and not agree to a meal or group photograph on their behalf. An apology can be recognized, and a new invitation can still be declined.

The publisher's description of Tutu's book about South Africa's truth and reconciliation process emphasizes that genuine reconciliation cannot be reached by denying the past. [2] That offers a direction worth retaining: the future cannot rest on pretending

events never happened. But the ethical questions a nation faces about its past cannot simply be reduced to a command that a private individual must attend, become close, or make peace.

## Four more weeks in the same home does not require a performance of closeness

Tang Mu and Liang Kai shared a rented home. Without permission, Liang Kai had let relatives or friends stay in Tang Mu's room for two nights. Afterward, he apologized, returned the key, and replaced a damaged desk lamp. Tang Mu acknowledged that these things had been done but still decided not to continue sharing the home.

Her new accommodation would not be available for four weeks, and finding another temporary place would add to her burden. There were no current threats. She chose to stay for those four weeks and continue the previously agreed sharing of utility bills and cleaning of communal areas. She did not want to eat together or leave personal belongings in Liang Kai's care anymore.

A mutual friend, A Xin, came to help coordinate. He was also due to become Liang Kai's next housemate and wanted to take over the room as soon as possible. A Xin could help confirm timings, but he had his own plans to advance. Knowing both people did not automatically make him a disinterested judge.

Tang Mu did not wait for everyone to endorse her feelings before arranging the transition. She clearly set out the cleaning rota for the remaining four weeks, the return of possessions, and the moving-out handover. She kept necessary contact focused on

those matters rather than adding meals and chats. A Xin could relay handover information, but not say on her behalf that she had forgiven Liang Kai or treat her silence as agreement to continue sharing the home.

The arrangement did not make seeing each other easy. It separated unavoidable matters from personal closeness. Choosing to stay temporarily did not approve the original behavior. Completing her agreed share of the work did not accept a new commitment to the relationship.

Real conditions sometimes mean leaving takes time. That makes specific arrangements more important, not a demand that “Since you’re still living together, stop making an issue of it.” If threats, repeated entry into private space, or other ongoing intrusions arise, contact and support arrangements need reconsidering. Immediate safety should not be ignored for the sake of completing a four-week plan. If no independent coordinator is available, do not pretend there is one.

## You need not first decide how you ought to feel

Someone can recognize that a remedy matters while still not wanting closeness. They may later be willing to try again but agree only to a small collaboration with clear limits. Feelings can fluctuate while arrangements remain specific.

“That part has been dealt with. This is as far as I’m willing to go now. I haven’t agreed to the new request.” Such an answer is more useful than providing proof that you have fully let go. It neither denies the harm nor decides in advance that someone can never change.

The future of a relationship may involve closeness, limited contact, or an orderly end to shared affairs. What matters is that past wrongs are not erased and that someone else’s decision does not once again replace the affected person’s own next step.

**Source notes** [1] P09, Russell and Warmke, *Forgiveness*, fixed Spring 2026 edition. Sections 1, 2.5, and 6.1 were checked; other sections, including 2.1–2.5, were also read only within a limited scope. The full entry, appendices, and original books cited were not read. This is conceptual and ethical discussion, not a psychological experiment or treatment prescription. [2] P08, publisher’s description of Tutu’s *No Future Without Forgiveness*. The Book Description was reread; this was not a close reading of the book itself. Bystanders’ costs, the characters’ feelings, the housing transition, and choices about autonomy are this book’s interpretations and fictional design, not universal accounts of motives or legal conclusions. See References and Scope of Consultation.

Part VI

# Turning Understanding into Ability

**Chapter 16**

# How to Turn Understanding into Sustained Action

*The meetings, household discussion, client communication, and reading situations below are original fiction, not data on learning outcomes.*

Several things stand between knowing what to do and actually doing it when needed. You must recognize an opportunity, remember the approach you intend to use, have the means to carry it out, and then notice what actually happens afterward.

While reading, the principle is right in front of you. In an argument, what catches your attention first is often the remark that stings. If you explain every failure as “I’m still not disciplined enough,” you may count a badly placed reminder, an unrehearsed action, and an inherently difficult problem as nothing but weak willpower.

This chapter proposes a practical approach: **connect one specific action to a real opportunity, then adjust according to what happens. Do not record only whether you ticked a box, and do not treat the other person’s agreement as the sole measure of whether you have learned.**

## Put reminders where they can be used

Rui Qing wrote in her notes, “Understand the situation first; don’t rush to argue back.” At Tuesday’s project meeting, a colleague said reviews were too slow. She immediately began explaining why all those steps had been necessary in the past. Only after the meeting did she remember her note. She set the sentence as her phone’s background.

At the next day’s short meeting, the phone was still in her bag. The reminder had not entered the meeting, but the old reaction had already appeared. Rui Qing later realized she had prepared a reminder without arranging when she would see it.

Before the next regular meeting, she put a question on the first page of her meeting notes: when someone complains that reviews are slow, first ask where the most recent one got stuck. She asked a colleague to rehearse with her. She found that as soon as she heard “We’ve already waited three days,” she wanted to explain the entire process, so she practiced letting the other person finish one example first.

On Thursday, she did ask the question. She learned that her colleague did not know who had received the application. She noted that unknown and agreed to check after the meeting rather than immediately promising to shorten every review. She had made a start on one occasion; the problem still needed work.

Human memory is not an instruction manual that automatically opens to the right page whenever needed. The summary of *How People Learn II* emphasizes that environmental cues affect what we can recall. [1] Placing Rui Qing’s question where she records

specific difficulties is this book's application of that idea. The problem was not that her phone background was insufficiently attractive, and copying the sentence ten more times would not guarantee remembering it.

Planning in advance also leaves one fewer decision for the moment itself. "Communicate better in future" still requires deciding on the spot how to begin. "When I hear that reviews are slow, ask where the last one got stuck" specifies a recognizable opportunity and an opening action beforehand. The "implementation intentions" studied by Gollwitzer and Sheeran concern precisely this connection between a particular situation and an intended action. [2] Their research informs the arrangement; it does not guarantee the effectiveness of this chapter's particular sentence.

The first step should be small enough to take and open to revision. Deal first with matters that require immediate action. If someone has clearly said they do not want to talk, do not pursue them merely to complete a question. A plan supports decisions; it does not replace judgment about the situation.

## Practice an opening, not a fixed conversation

Tang Chu and his partner agreed to spend a short time after dinner on Sundays discussing the following week's housework. Previously, he had waited until they were complaining at each other. He then practiced asking what needed adjusting once the dinner table had been cleared.

After a few weeks, starting the discussion was less difficult. One evening, his partner had just finished a demanding rush of work and said they did not want to plan anything else that day. They could talk after work tomorrow. Tang Chu almost continued down the list, as though asking the first question meant the whole round had to be completed.

Instead, he confirmed the next day's time and stopped. The household discussion was not completed that evening, but neither did he turn practice into another imposed task. Once the opening became familiar, the choices that followed still had to respond to the people and circumstances.

Lally and colleagues asked participants to repeat an eating, drinking, or activity-related behavior in the same everyday context and report whether it increasingly occurred without deliberate reminders. Changes varied greatly between people. [3] This is not a timetable for developing complex interpersonal abilities. It cannot specify how many days it takes to become a capable communicator.

Repetition may make the opening easier to initiate. It cannot turn all the subsequent listening, comparison, and decision-making into a script. If someone wants to speak, listen carefully. If they have asked for another time, arrange it. However practiced your actions become, repeatedly steering the other person back to your planned sequence may take you further from the original purpose.

You need not manufacture opportunities when none arise. A day without the relevant disagreement does not mean practice has failed. Someone not wanting to talk does not require finding another issue to complete your record. Sustained action should fit life, not make life serve a planning sheet.

## Reviewing the experience should locate the sticking point

Su Yao wanted to begin client requests for revisions by clarifying the usability problem to be solved. During one discussion, she asked, but interrupted when the client said, “Readers often can’t find where to start,” and began explaining her design. Afterward, she wrote in her record: “Asked. Didn’t help.”

Only after hearing a colleague recount the exchange did she notice that she had asked the question without hearing the full answer. She knew only that the client had mentioned an entry point. She still did not know where readers looked, how long they searched, or at what stage they left. The project’s failure to run smoothly at once did not mean that none of the preceding steps had occurred. Asking one question did not mean the problem was understood either.

She changed her record to a brief account: I asked first; when the client mentioned finding the entry point, I interrupted. I still need a concrete example of how it is used. Next time, let the client finish that example. She did not retain the client’s private conversation or label herself “unsuited to communication.”

That changes how she prepares next time. If you did not understand, return to the material and clarify it. If you understood but did not remember, examine the opportunity and reminder. If you remembered but could not act, practice that particular action. If you acted and the problem remained, examine the process and actual conditions. This is the book's way of organizing reflection, not a scale for sorting people into types.

In particular, distinguish your own actions from outcomes controlled by others. You can make a problem clear; you cannot independently guarantee that a client, colleague, or family member will agree. If the bottleneck turns out to be staffing and time, arrangements must change. Continuing to practice phrasing does not mean resources have increased.

## What remains after you close the book?

Yao Ning underlined many passages while reading about interpersonal communication. Each paragraph felt familiar when she reread it. Three days later, a companion asked what she should say if she could not finish work she had already agreed to do. The first thing she remembered was only "Maintain your boundaries."

Opening the book again, she noticed the missing half: a commitment has already affected other people's arrangements, so changing it requires timely explanation and attention to the consequences. She did not recopy the whole chapter. She wrote the distinction in her own words, then tried to explain it again a couple of days later.

Recognizing the text and being able to explain it yourself are different things. Dunlosky and colleagues' review of learning techniques rates practice testing and distributed practice as having high utility. [4] What is borrowed here is voluntary, brief recall spread across days, not a requirement that readers take a test after every passage. Nor does remembering something directly establish an improvement in real relationships.

If you can explain a choice in your own words and then check what you left out, you have something to improve next. A goal that no longer fits can also be adjusted or paused. Sustained action does not mean loyalty to the first plan you wrote.

The next time you need a principle, ask which specific action you intend to take and when the opportunity will arise. After acting, retain a few sentences about what happened, enough to inform the next judgment. Change then has a practical starting point instead of remaining another round of self-reproach about why you have not improved.

**Source notes** [1] R07, *How People Learn II*, Summary. Consultation covered Conclusion 4-2 and relevant passages on learning strategies, not the whole report. [2] R02, paper page at the author's university. Bibliographic information was checked and the abstract and introduction on the first three pages of the original scan, printed pages 69–71, were reread visually. The online PDF did not return readable text. The full 49 pages were not read and effect sizes were not checked. [3] R03, original abstract of Lally and colleagues. The abstract was checked; no timetable for developing complex communication is inferred. [4] R04, the review publisher's official introduction. The passage rating methods was reread, not the entire review. The four stories and learning arrangements are original applications. They have not been tested for effects on actual readers, behavior, or models. See References and Scope of Consultation.

For comparing new circumstances, see the next chapter.

**Chapter 17**

# How to Make Fresh Judgments in Unfamiliar Situations

*The interviews, garden, recording preparations, and tool outputs below are original fiction, not research data, actual projects, or real AI tests.*

When we encounter a new problem, it is easy to look first for an answer we have seen before. Experience can save us from starting from scratch. It can also make us decide too soon: this is just like last time, so do the same thing.

What needs comparing is not merely that two people both said no. It also includes what each originally agreed to, who has authority to decide what, and which conditions actually exist now. **An approach you have learned can provide a starting point; it cannot fill in the facts of a new situation in advance. When key conditions change, actions and goals must be allowed to change too.**

## Agreeing to an interview does not mean agreeing to every later use

A volunteer group spanning several cities was preparing to publish a collection of stories about old shops. Qiao An sent De Ning a two-page summary, already laid out, asking him to approve it by Wednesday. His response was, “This isn’t appropriate.” Other group members felt that, having agreed to the interview, he should not now make everyone redo the work.

Qiao An almost treated this as a problem of persuading someone to cooperate. They prepared to explain the public benefit and ask him to identify which sentences needed changing. Before sending the message, they reopened the original invitation. Only then did they see that it described sharing within the group. Making the material public had been a later decision by the team. De Ning had not separately agreed.

It was the team that had first changed the terms. Qiao An paused publication of this piece and checked the scope again. De Ning also pointed out that the summary had cut his nuanced assessment into unqualified praise and mentioned an acquaintance who still lived locally. He was willing to share within the group, but not to make the material public for now.

Qiao An withdrew this piece from the public-edition layout, checked the other interview invitations, and divided the reworking tasks with their colleagues. “How do we get him to agree?” was no longer their sole objective. The layout time already spent was a real cost, but it could not consent to a new use on the interviewee’s behalf.

*How People Learn II* notes that prior knowledge can support learning but can also lead people to overlook new information and rely on previous understanding. [1] The familiarity that experience brings can sometimes cause us to skip precisely the fact that could change a decision.

Qiao An retained the practice of first understanding concerns, but abandoned the assumption that the team was already entitled to demand publication. That came closer to the change actually needed than simply phrasing the original pressure more

gently. What they needed to check was not whether De Ning cared enough about a public-interest project, but what he had originally agreed to.

## New conditions may also require a smaller goal

Li Quan planned to open a shared garden from nine to noon on Saturday. Seeing Bai Yin's name on the watering roster, he thought he could also assign him Saturday supervision. Bai Yin refused. He had agreed only to water for about twenty minutes each Monday and Wednesday, and already had plans for Saturday morning.

After checking the roster, Li Quan confirmed that no one had agreed to cover the three hours for him. He would be out of town that day. Ji Yun had confirmed availability only from nine to ten-thirty. Other members could not cover the remaining time, and outside help had not been secured. No announcement had been made and no visitors had booked. The group allowed shortening or postponing the opening, but someone had to have explicitly agreed to supervise whenever the garden was open.

Li Quan shortened this opening to end at ten-thirty. He first obtained the group's confirmation, then announced the hours they could actually provide. Bai Yin continued watering without acquiring a Saturday duty as a result. The originally intended three-hour event did not happen in full, but the plan no longer depended on someone who had not agreed to stay.

This scenario involves neither interviews nor public materials. What needs changing is the opening time and the staffing. Its similarity to the previous story is that an existing commitment cannot be casually enlarged. The difference is what needs doing once the facts are clear. In the interview case, unconfirmed use must first stop. In the garden case, an event not yet announced can be reduced.

The abstract of Gentner and colleagues' research on learning in negotiation reports that, within the tasks studied, comparing two cases together helped participants apply what they learned to subsequent negotiation tasks more than studying the cases separately. [2] This book draws on that finding to encourage examining similarities and differences together, not treating comparison as an exercise in finding every possible reason two situations are alike.

The most useful differences are those that change the action. A task explicitly accepted cannot be handled as though "I never agreed to the new request." Nor will repeating communication principles conjure up staff who have not been secured. Checking which condition determines this choice is more practical than applying every term in the book.

## A complete table can rest on consent that does not exist

An eight-person amateur guide group wanted to record two audio-guide trial segments on Saturday. The coordinator, Zhou Cen, entered a studio quote of 1,200 yuan for two hours into an AI tool

and asked it to produce a cost-sharing table. The table was clear: eight people, 150 yuan each. She almost sent it directly as a payment notice.

But joining the group had involved an agreement to weekly rehearsals, not all additional costs. Jian Sheng had already declined any extra expenses that month. The funds actually available were 300 yuan in surplus funds the group had approved for the trial recording, plus voluntary contributions of 150 yuan from each of five people: 1,050 yuan in total. Eight payments in a table did not come with eight people's consent.

Zhou Cen checked the quote again. One hour cost 800 yuan, and there was no two-hour minimum. Only two trial segments were planned; they could be recorded as intended in an hour, and a Saturday slot was available. She submitted the shorter option to the members for confirmation. She did not list people who had not agreed as contributors or assume she must cover the difference herself.

The AI had neither collected money for her nor agreed on the members' behalf. It had simply produced a suggested table from the input. The problem was that a neat, fluent answer could make someone forget to check where the table's conditions came from. This is a check proposed through a fictional task, not a measured finding about a particular model.

Tools can help compare options. They cannot vouch for missing facts. When using such tools, you can provide only fictional or appropriately processed material and ask for a response based on the known conditions. Leave information you have not established as unknown, and do not let a tool decide for real people.

Actual interviews, private conversations, and professional questions must still be handled according to the applicable data-handling requirements. Being able to paste something does not mean you should upload it all.

*How People Learn II* also asks that learning technologies be evaluated in light of learning goals, learners, environments, and support conditions. [3] Sustaining a conversation is a function. Whether a tool helps readers understand, remember, and make choices in new circumstances requires corresponding evidence. One cannot substitute for the other.

## Let new circumstances replace old answers

Stories you have read can be used for comparison and review. Repeating the correct choice after you already know the ending does not count as a new instance of applying learning to an unfamiliar situation. If you wish to practice, choose a scenario you have not read before. Make a judgment, check the conditions, then explain which fact led you to revise the arrangement.

You need not change your answer every time. If checking shows that the original judgment remains supported, keep it. The point is not to return to the same conclusion regardless of what you discover. Acknowledging that you still do not know, or finding an appropriate professional when help is needed, is also part of judgment.

Qiao An stopped an unconfirmed publication. Li Quan shortened hours for which no one had committed to supervise. Zhou Cen did not use a table to assign everyone a payment. None changed course because they remembered more terminology. They noticed which facts could not be covered over by the original plan.

When taking learning somewhere new, bring the ability to ask questions, check conditions, and explain your reasons. You need not bring the old answers unchanged. Willingness to judge afresh when conditions differ gives the principles you have learned a chance to remain useful.

**Source notes** [1] R07, *How People Learn II*, Summary. Conclusion 5-1 was checked, not the entire report. [2] R05, the authors' school's abstract of Gentner and colleagues' original paper. The abstract covering three negotiation-learning experiments was reread; the full text was not read. It is not extrapolated into evidence of real-world transfer from this book's cases. [3] R07, Conclusions 8-1, 8-2, and 9-1 in the same Summary. The learning effects of the tools discussed here have not been validated. The actions, costs, and conditions of consent in all three cases are original fictional designs, not legal conclusions or findings about venues or recording quality. See References and Scope of Consultation.

# References and Reading Scope

The identifiers below match the sources used in this edition's chapters. They preserve the manuscript's reference keys, not a ranking of importance or reading depth. The chapters explain the specific claims and limitations; this list provides bibliographic information, the material actually consulted, and locations within it. The reading scope comes from the Chinese manuscript's source records. Translating and typesetting this edition did not extend it into a new review of the original literature.

Research results cannot diagnose fictional characters. Method summaries, authors' proposals, and this book's interpretations are not interchangeable. Historical sources not cited in the current chapters are excluded from this list.

## P02 Nonviolent Communication Quick Reference Guide

Inbal Kashtan, Miki Kashtan.

Used in chapters: 3, 7, 9, 11, 12.

Material consulted: The practical guidance on the webpage.

Location: Observations; Feelings; Needs; Requests; Empathy.

Source page

## P03 Getting to Yes

Roger Fisher, William L. Ury, Bruce Patton (2011).

Used in chapters: 6, 9, 10.

Material consulted: Publisher's description and bibliographic information; not the complete book.

Location: Method points in the Book Description.

Source page

## P04 Identity and Violence: The Illusion of Destiny

Amartya Sen (2007).

Used in chapters: 5.

Material consulted: A public description of the book, not a full close reading. The page lists a 2007 edition.

Location: Abstract on the Weatherhead bibliographic page.

Source page

## P05 Xiangtu Zhongguo (Chinese edition)

Fei Xiaotong (2025 edition).

Used in chapters: 5.

Material consulted: The Commercial Press description and contents for the 2025 Chinese edition, not a close reading of the original book.

Location: Description, table of contents, and bibliographic information; ISBN 9787100251389.

Source page

## P06 Governing the Commons: The Evolution of Institutions for Collective Action

Elinor Ostrom (1990).

Used in chapters: 6.

Material consulted: Cambridge's publisher description and contents, not a full close reading.

Location: Book description and Contents.

Source page · DOI:10.1017/CBO9780511807763

## P07 The Science of Persuasion / Seven Principles of Persuasion

Robert B. Cialdini / Influence at Work.

Used in chapters: 12.

Material consulted: Relevant text on the author's official method webpage; the original experiments were not read individually.

Location: Reciprocity, Scarcity, Authority, Consistency, Social Proof.

Source page

## P08 No Future Without Forgiveness

Desmond Tutu (2000).

Used in chapters: 15.

Material consulted: Publisher's description and edition information, not a close reading of the original book.

Location: Book Description; information for the 2000 paperback edition.

Source page

## P09 Forgiveness

Luke Russell, Brandon Warmke (2026).

Used in chapters: 15.

Material consulted: Specified sections and author/version information; not the whole entry, appendices, or original books cited by the entry.

Location: Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, Spring 2026; sections 1, 2.1–2.5, 6.1, and related passages on disagreements; the version-information page.

Source page · Author or institutional bibliography

## R01 Understanding Psychological Reactance: New Developments and Findings

Christina Steindl, Eva Jonas, Sandra Sittenthaler, Eva Traut-Mattausch, Jeff Greenberg (2015).

Used in chapters: 9.

Material consulted: The publicly available original abstract and bibliographic information, not the full paper. The abstract hosted by an author's institution was used for checking; this does not extend the reading scope.

Location: Original abstract and bibliographic record, including the institutional Abstract. The PubMed page returned only its footer during that check.

Source page · DOI:10.1027/2151-2604/a000222 · Author or institutional bibliography

## R02 Implementation intentions and goal achievement: A meta-analysis of effects and processes

Peter M. Gollwitzer, Paschal Sheeran (2006).

Used in chapters: 16.

Material consulted: The first three pages were read visually; all forty-nine pages were not rechecked.

Location: Public scanned PDF, pages 1–3 (printed pages 69–71): abstract and introduction.

Source page · DOI:10.1016/S0065-2601(06)38002-1 · Paper access

## R03 How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world

Phillippa Lally, Cornelia H. M. van Jaarsveld, Henry W. W. Potts, Jane Wardle (2010).

Used in chapters: 16.

Material consulted: Original abstract and bibliographic information. First published online on July 16, 2009.

Location: Wiley Abstract; volume 40, issue 6, pages 998–1009.

Source page · DOI:10.1002/ejsp.674

## R04 Improving Students' Learning With Effective Learning Techniques: Promising Directions From Cognitive and Educational Psychology

John Dunlosky, Katherine A. Rawson, Elizabeth J. Marsh, Mitchell J. Nathan, Daniel T. Willingham (2013).

Used in chapters: 16.

Material consulted: Original abstract and the APS introduction, not the full paper.

Location: Utility assessments in the Abstract; APS's official introduction.

Source page · DOI:10.1177/1529100612453266 · Publisher introduction

## R05 Learning and Transfer: A General Role for Analogical Encoding

Dedre Gentner, Jeffrey Loewenstein, Leigh Thompson (2003).

Used in chapters: 17.

Material consulted: The original abstract on an author's school website, not the full paper.

Location: Abstract after Author(s) on the paper page; Experiments 2 and 3.

Source page

## R07 How People Learn II: Learners, Contexts, and Cultures

National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine (2018).

Used in chapters: 16, 17.

Material consulted: Relevant portions of the report's Summary, including conclusions on memory prompts and prior knowledge; not a close reading of the entire report.

Location: Specified passages in the Summary: Conclusions 4-2, 5-1, 5-3/5-4, 8-1, 8-2, and 9-1.

Source page · DOI:10.17226/24783

## R08 Does changing behavioral intentions engender behavior change? A meta-analysis of the experimental evidence

Thomas L. Webb, Paschal Sheeran (2006).

Used in chapters: 1.

Material consulted: Original abstract and bibliographic record on PubMed.

Location: Abstract.

Source page · DOI:10.1037/0033-2909.132.2.249

## R09 Contingencies of Self-Worth

Jennifer Crocker, Katherine M. Knight (2005).

Used in chapters: 2, 10.

Material consulted: Publisher's original abstract and bibliographic record; the restricted full text was not read.

Location: Abstract.

Source page · DOI:10.1111/j.0963-7214.2005.00364.x

## R10 Considering the opposite: a corrective strategy for social judgment

C. G. Lord, M. R. Lepper, E. Preston (1984).

Used in chapters: 3.

Material consulted: Original abstract and bibliographic record on PubMed.

Location: Abstract: descriptions of the two experiments and the comparison instructions.

Source page · DOI:10.1037//0022-3514.47.6.1231

## R11 The Correspondence Bias

Daniel T. Gilbert, Patrick S. Malone (1995).

Used in chapters: 4.

Material consulted: The first page and limited passages in the specified sections, not all eighteen pages or a recheck of cited studies.

Location: Original PDF page 1, abstract and introduction; pages 5–6, Lack of Awareness; pages 9–10, Incomplete Corrections and relevant limitations.

Source page · DOI:10.1037/0033-2909.117.1.21

## R12 A Fine Is a Price

Uri Gneezy, Aldo Rustichini (2000).

Used in chapters: 6.

Material consulted: Selected methods, textual results, explanations of mechanisms, and conclusions; not a full reading of all eighteen pages or a recheck of all figures, statistical appendices, or original data.

Location: Original abstract/introduction; relevant passages in II The Study, III Results, IV.D Social Norms, and V Conclusions; PDF pages 3–5, 7–8, and 13–16.

Source page

## R13 An Integrative Model of Organizational Trust

Roger C. Mayer, James H. Davis, F. David Schoorman (1995).

Used in chapters: 13.

Material consulted: Specified relevant passages from the original paper, not a close reading of all twenty-six pages or a review of subsequent empirical work.

Location: Original abstract; university-hosted copy: definition on journal page 712, factors and distinctions on pages 717–721, and relevant context/limitations on pages 726–729.

Source page · DOI:10.2307/258792 · Paper access

## R14 An Exploration of the Structure of Effective Apologies

Roy J. Lewicki, Beth Polin, Robert B. Lount (2016).

Used in chapters: 14.

Material consulted: Abstract and bibliographic information. A PDF was located but not read in full.

Location: Abstract on the journal's paper page; 9(2), 177–196.

Source page · DOI:10.34891/9awp-8644 · Paper access

## R15 Thinking Backward: Some Curable and Incurable Consequences of Cognitive Busyness

Daniel T. Gilbert, Randall E. Osborne (1989).

Used in chapters: 4.

Material consulted: Original abstract and limited original passages on Experiment 1 methods and results; not a full recheck of twenty-three pages, the remaining experiments, or original data.

Location: Abstract; Experiment 1 Method and Results; relevant passages on public PDF pages 3–7.

Source page

## R16 Interpersonal Attraction in Exchange and Communal Relationships

Margaret S. Clark, Judson Mills (1979).

Used in chapters: 5.

Material consulted: Limited passages from the original paper, not all thirteen pages, a recheck of Experiment 2 methods, or original data. Bibliographic details were cross-checked against the author's laboratory publication list.

Location: Abstract, conceptual definitions, Experiment 1 methods and results, and relevant General Discussion passages; PDF pages 1–5 and 12, printed pages 12–16 and 23; JPSP 37(1), 12–24.

Source page · Author or institutional bibliography

## R17 Biased Judgments of Fairness in Bargaining

Linda Babcock, George Loewenstein, Samuel Issacharoff, Colin Camerer (1995).

Used in chapters: 6.

Material consulted: All seven pages of the scanned original paper were read visually. Original data were not recalculated and cited studies were not rechecked.

Location: AER 85(5), 1337–1343; I The Experiment, II Results, III Conclusions; PDF pages 2–6.

Source page

## R18 Biased judgements of fairness in bargaining: A replication in the laboratory

Sven Höppner, Svenja Hippel (2019).

Used in chapters: 6.

Material consulted: Only the accessible abstract, introduction excerpts, and bibliographic information; not the full text, methods, or original data.

Location: Abstract and public Introduction excerpts in search results for the publisher page; institutional bibliographic record; IRLE 58, 63–74.

Source page · DOI:10.1016/j.irle.2019.02.001 · Author or institutional bibliography

## R19 The Relative Effectiveness of Active Listening in Initial Interactions

Harry Weger, Gina Castle Bell, Elizabeth M. Minei, Melissa C. Robinson (2014).

Used in chapters: 7.

Material consulted: The institution-hosted original Abstract and bibliographic information, not the full text, complete methods, or original data.

Location: UCF's abstract and bibliographic record; International Journal of Listening 28(1), 13–31.

Source page · DOI:10.1080/10904018.2013.813234

## R20 Undervaluing Gratitude: Expressers Misunderstand the Consequences of Showing Appreciation

Amit Kumar, Nicholas Epley (2018).

Used in chapters: 8.

Material consulted: Public original abstract and bibliographic information, not the full text, detailed experimental methods, or open data.

Location: Publisher's Abstract and the same-title abstract in the author's public publication list; Psychological Science 29(9), 1423–1435.

Source page · DOI:10.1177/0956797618772506 · Author or institutional bibliography

## R21 The Effects of Feedback Interventions on Performance: A Historical Review, a Meta-Analysis, and a Preliminary Feedback Intervention Theory

Avraham N. Kluger, Angelo DeNisi (1996).

Used in chapters: 8.

Material consulted: Limited passages from a publicly accessible copy of the original paper; not a complete reading of thirty-one pages, an individual recheck of included studies, or recalculation of original data. An institutional bibliography was used to check the record.

Location: Abstract and definitions; relevant theory on PDF pages 9 and 13–16, and discussion and limitations on pages 22–23; Psychological Bulletin 119(2), 254–284.

Source page · DOI:10.1037/0033-2909.119.2.254 · Author or institutional bibliography

## R22 Objectivity in the eye of the beholder: divergent perceptions of bias in self versus others

Emily Pronin, Thomas Gilovich, Lee Ross (2004).

Used in chapters: 10.

Material consulted: Original abstract and bibliographic record, not the full text, included studies, or original data.

Location: Original Abstract; Psychological Review 111(3), 781–799.

Source page · DOI:10.1037/0033-295X.111.3.781

## R23 If you need help, just ask: underestimating compliance with direct requests for help

Francis J. Flynn, Vanessa K. B. Lake (2008).

Used in chapters: 11.

Material consulted: Original abstract, author names as published, and bibliographic information; not the full text, individual methods, or original data.

Location: Original Abstract, particularly Study 6's distinction between social and practical costs; JPSP 95(1), 128–143.

Source page · DOI:10.1037/0022-3514.95.1.128

## R24 Effects of a Favor and Liking on Compliance

Dennis T. Regan (1971).

Used in chapters: 12.

Material consulted: Limited passages from the publicly accessible original paper; not a full recheck of thirteen pages, original data, cited studies, or modern replication evidence.

Location: Abstract; design and sample passages on PDF pages 4–5; textual results and discussion on pages 6–11; JESP 7, 627–639.

Source page · DOI:10.1016/0022-1031(71)90025-4

## R25 An affirmed self and a better apology: The effect of self-affirmation on transgressors' responses to victims

Karina Schumann (2014).

Used in chapters: 14.

Material consulted: Specified passages in the original paper publicly hosted by the author's laboratory; not a close reading of all eight pages, recalculation of statistics, or a replication check.

Location: JESP 54, 89–96; abstract, Barriers section, Experiment 1 methods/results, relevant Experiment 2 methods/results, and General discussion.

Source page · DOI:10.1016/j.jesp.2014.04.013

## A starting point for the book

Dale Carnegie, *How to Win Friends and Influence People*. This was one starting point for the questions behind this book. The material consulted was the publisher's description and bibliographic information, not the full original book. It is not used as evidence for specific methods or research conclusions in the current chapters. The 2022 date in the source record refers to the listed edition, not the original first publication.

Publisher's description and bibliographic record.